

Regularisation of properties in unauthorised colonies begins

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Residents of over 1,500 unauthorised colonies in the city will be able to apply online for registration of their properties through the Swagam portal of the MCD from Friday, officials said.

The Centre earlier this month rolled out a new policy for the regularisation of unauthorised colonies in Delhi on “as is where is” basis. According to the guidelines, the applicants will log on to the SWAGAM portal of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) for registration of their properties in the identified 1,521 unauthorised colonies.

The applications of property owners who have conveyance deeds (properties on government land) or authorisation slips (properties on private land) issued



earlier by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will apply for regularisation. Those who do not have conveyance deeds or authorisation slips will be redirected to the PM-UDAY portal through which they will be issued these documents, the officials said.

Under the new policy, the power to issue conveyance deeds or authorisation slips

has been transferred from the DDA to the Revenue Department of the Delhi Government.

A Revenue Department officer said that dedicated cells under additional district magistrates (ADMs) are being formed for issuing conveyance deeds. The ADMs in the 13 districts will serve as nodal officers for the purpose.

The regularisation process will benefit over 10 lakh households in the 1,521 unauthorised colonies. The DDA earlier issued around 40,000 conveyance deeds and authorisation slips.

A detailed standard operating procedure (SOP) is being finalised for the regularisation process, the officials said.

Based on the conveyance deeds and authorisation slips, the property owners will be issued regularisation certificates by the MCD through its SWAGAM portal, the officials said.

Afterwards, the property owners using the regularisation certificates will be able to register their properties with the Revenue Department sub-registrars through the National Generic Document Registration System (NGDRS) portal, they said.

Govt to open Atal Canteen at AIIMS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is set to open an Atal Canteen at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) here. With increased operating hours, from 10 am to 10 pm, and service extending beyond the existing fixed lunch and dinner slots, the canteen is aimed at catering to patients' attendants and visitors who spend long hours at the hospital.

A tender has been floated by the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB) for the construction of the Atal Canteen at AIIMS at an estimated cost of ₹29.74 lakh, according to an official.

He said the project has been given a 45-day time-frame for completion.

Unlike the current Atal Canteen model, where meals are served in two fixed slots — Lunch from 11.30 am to 2 pm and dinner from 6.30 pm to 9 pm — the proposed hospital-linked



canteen will remain operational for 12 hours continuously, he said.

The official said the move is aimed at meeting the needs of patients' families and attendants who often stay at hospitals for extended periods and require access to affordable meals throughout the day.

The Government had allocated ₹104 crore for implementing the Atal Canteen scheme across the city.

Around 40 additional canteens are planned near government hospitals as part of the expansion.

The Atal Canteen initiative was launched on December 25 last year by the BJP-led Delhi Government on the birth anniversary of former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Under the scheme, nutritious meals comprising chapati, rice, vegetable curry and pickle are provided at ₹5 per plate to address food insecurity among economically weaker sections.

Each canteen currently serves up to 500 plates for lunch and 500 for dinner daily, with visitors required to collect QR-based tokens before receiving meals.

POLICE BUST LPG BLACK MARKETING RACKETS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police Crime Branch has busted two illegal LPG cylinder black marketing rackets operating in Mangolpuri and Jahangirpuri, arresting five accused and recovering 104 cylinders along with vehicles and equipment used for illegal refilling and sale.

The operation, based on specific intelligence inputs, exposed a large-scale network involved in hoarding and unauthorised refilling of domestic and commercial LPG cylinders. Police also seized four vehicles, two refilling machines, three digital weighing scales, and pipes fitted with regulators and nozzles used in the illegal activity.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime Branch-IV) Pankaj Kumar said the action was part of sustained efforts to curb black marketing and ensure public safety. He said the crackdown prevented potential hazards in densely populated areas and disrupted illegal profiteering.

According to police, the first raid was conducted in Mangolpuri near a gas agency in T-Block. Three accused, identified as Santosh, Sachin Kumar, and Pramod Pal, were caught while illegally storing and refilling LPG cylinders. A total of 73 cylinders were recovered from the spot. The team also seized three vehicles used for transporting the cylinders, along with refilling equipment and weighing machines.

In a parallel operation, another team raided a location in Jahangirpuri near Mahendra Park. Two accused, Mahesh Pal and Kishan Yadav, were apprehended while unloading LPG cylinders from a modified cycle rickshaw into a shop.

IPL match to trigger traffic curbs near Arun Jaitley Stadium

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



the match.

Commuters have been advised to avoid major stretches including JLN Marg from Rajghat to Delhi Gate, Asaf Ali Road from Turkman Gate to Delhi Gate, and Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg from Delhi Gate to ITO. Both carriageways on these roads are likely to witness heavy congestion as spectators arrive and disperse.

Restrictions will also apply to the movement of heavy and commercial vehicles. Such vehicles will not be allowed on Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg between Daryaganj and Delhi Gate, on JLN Marg between Delhi Gate and Guru Nanak Chowk, and on the stretch from ITO to Delhi Gate. These restrictions will remain in force during peak hours of match-related movement.

Police said entry to the stadium will be regulated through designated gates. Gates 1 to 8, located on the southern side, will be accessible from Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg. Gates 10 to 15, on the eastern side, can be accessed via JLN Marg near Ambedkar Stadium Bus Terminal.

LG Sandhu attends SRCC's 100th Annual Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday attended the 100th Annual Day celebrations of Shri Ram College of Commerce at its campus, describing the centenary as a reflection of continuity, resilience and relevance, and calling on students to approach their careers with both confidence and a sense of responsibility toward society.

The event was attended by Rajat Sharma, Chairman of SRCC's Governing Body, Ajay S Shriram, and Principal Prof Simrit Kaur, along with faculty members, students, parents, and alumni. Founded in 1926 by Sir Shri Ram, SRCC has com-



pleted a hundred years as one of India's premier institutions in commerce and economics. The LG said the college's founding vision, to prepare young minds for leadership in commerce and public life, remains as relevant today as it was a century ago.

"A centenary is not merely a marker of time. It is a reflection of continuity,

resilience, and relevance," Sandhu said in his address. "For a hundred years, SRCC has not only sustained excellence but has consistently adapted to changing academic, economic, and social landscapes."

Sandhu recalled his previous visit to the campus in 2016, when he attended an Indo-US programme organised by the college's Office of

International Programmes, under its coordinator, Prof. Malleeta Kumar. He said it was meaningful to revisit the campus and reflect on the institution's journey.

In his address, the LG drew attention to the broader national context in which institutions like SRCC operate. He said India is at a significant juncture, with a growing economy, expanding global engagement, and rapid technological transformation creating both opportunities and challenges for young professionals.

He pointed to emerging areas, including digital finance, entrepreneurship, data analytics, and global trade, as fields where trained and ethically grounded individuals are increasingly needed.





Yogi Adityanath
Chief Minister, U.P.



Nand Gopal Gupta "Nandi"
Minister of Industrial Development, U.P.



Jaswant Singh Saini
State Minister Industrial Development, U.P.





Strategically planned as a next-generation growth corridor, YEIDA is fast emerging as a hub where world-class infrastructure, future-ready industries, and seamless connectivity converge. Elevated by the Noida International Airport, YEIDA is driving investment, innovation, and employment. At 25, YEIDA is dedicated to move forward with renewed momentum, advancing Uttar Pradesh's \$1 trillion economy vision and Viksit Bharat.

Milestones YEIDA @ 25

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Prime location along 100 m. wide Yamuna Expressway with seamless regional connectivity.



Land Bank Strength
3,000+ hectares of planned development area ensuring long-term expansion and scalability.



Urban Infrastructure Push
Planned sectors with integrated roads, utilities, green spaces, and social infrastructure for sustainable urban living.



Reliable Power Infrastructure
Dedicated substations and high-capacity transmission network, ensuring uninterrupted, quality power supply.

Unmatched Connectivity



India's Aviation Gateway
Noida International Airport – 11,700+ acres, 225 million passenger annual capacity.



Logistics & Freight Advantage
Eastern Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC) | Airport DFC Connectivity | 87-acre cargo hub | Airport to Delhi Mumbai Expressway connecting Road.



Connectivity Boost
Proposed High Speed Rail Connectivity from Delhi-Varanasi | Rail Connectivity from Chola (Kolkata - Howrah Line) to Runderi (Mumbai Line) | Proposed Rapid Rail Transit System (RTTS)



Expressway Network
100 m. wide Eastern Peripheral Expressway | 130 m. wide Road Greater Noida to YEIDA | 100 m. wide Expressway Palwal to Khurja | Ganga Expressway | Connectivity to Delhi - Mumbai Expressway

Industrial Footprints



Investment Magnet
Rs 50,000+ crore investments since 2017; strong policy support.



Industrial Expansion
2,200+ plots across 2,730+ acres driving industrial growth.



Employment Generator
Nearly 4 lakh jobs across sectors.

Planned for Development



Sectoral Mega Parks
Clusters for Medical Devices, Data Centres, Apparel, MSME, Toys Handicrafts & Semiconductor Park.



Electronics Hub
Electronic manufacturing cluster in Sector 10



Global Districts
Singapore, Japanese & Korean Cities – 500 acres each.



Fintech Hub
Upcoming integrated ecosystem of offices, retail & residences.



International Film City
230+ acres of world-class film production facility.

Future Master Plan: A path of growth



Upcoming Logistics Hub in Tappal Bajna Urban Centre



Upcoming Heritage City in Raya Urban Centre Mathura



Upcoming Master Planning of Hathras Urban Centre



Upcoming Master Planning of Agra Urban Centre



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IN FOCUS



A priest performs rituals during the Ganga Saptami festival at Dashashwamedh Ghat in Varanasi

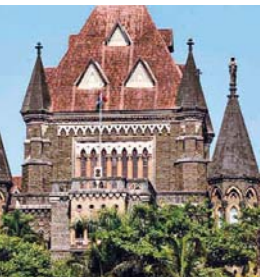
PTI

Malegaon case: Bombay HC discharges 4 accused

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The 2006 Malegaon blasts case “seems to have reached a dead end,” the Bombay High Court said while discharging four accused and pulling up the National Investigation Agency (NIA) for “completely ignoring” incriminating evidence collected by previous probing agencies.

The high court’s order, which was passed on Wednesday and made available on Thursday, leaves unanswered the significant question of who was responsible for the September 8, 2006, explosions that claimed 31 lives and injured 312 others. A division bench of Chief



Justice Shree Chandrashekhar and Justice Shyam Chandak quashed a September 2025 special court order that had framed charges against Rajendra Chaudhary, Dhan Singh, Manohar Ram Singh Narwaria, and Lokesh Sharma. “The case seems to have reached a dead end. The diagonally opposite stories in the chargesheet

filed by the ATS and the NIA lead nowhere,” said the HC order, made available on Thursday.

The bench said that the special judge had not “applied his mind” and overlooked the “inherent contradiction and intrinsic improbability” of the NIA’s prosecution story, which relied on retracted confessions and circumstantial hearsay rather than fresh material. In reaching to this conclusion, the high court anchored its judgment in legal principles established during the pre-Independence era, citing rulings from 1914 and 1934.

The bench referenced Lord Sumner’s 1914 judgment (Ibrahim versus The King), which established

the “positive rule” that no statement by an accused is admissible unless proven voluntary and not obtained through fear or hope of advantage.

The court also cited Lord Russell of Killowen’s 1934 ruling (Sheo Swarup versus King Emperor), emphasising that an appellate court must not be burdened by the trial court’s opinion but must independently review the weight and reliability of all evidence.

The high court said the NIA’s probe “completely ignored” the initial probe by the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS), which provided a “vivid narration” involving nine Muslim men arrested earlier in the case.

Delhi Cantt hospital gets robotic orthopaedic system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh on Thursday inaugurated the Robotic Orthopaedic System and Maternity Operation Theatre at Cantonment General Hospital, Delhi Cantonment, in the presence of Director General, Defence Estates, Shobha Gupta. The facilities will provide advanced healthcare services for the residents of the Cantonment and neighbouring municipal areas.

Speaking on the occasion, the Defence Secretary emphasized the importance of modernising healthcare infrastructure in Cantonments and highlighted the government’s continued commitment to ensuring high quality medical services for residents. The Director General Defence Estates lauded the initiative, noting

that such developments will significantly strengthen healthcare delivery systems within cantonment areas and contribute to overall community welfare. The newly launched Robotic Orthopaedic System represents a major technological upgrade, enabling precision-driven surgical procedures, reduced recovery times and improved patient outcomes. Equipped with a cutting-edge robotic system, the unit is expected to enhance the hospital’s capability in handling complex orthopaedic cases with greater accuracy and efficiency.

On the occasion, a brief presentation was also made on the planned upgrades at Cantonment General Hospital which includes a Dialysis Centre, Central Sterile Services Department , ICU upgrades, and laboratory expansion over the next three months.

Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train enters key phase

PIONNER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail Corridor, India’s first bullet train project, is progressing steadily. Spanning approximately 508 km, the corridor will connect Mumbai and Ahmedabad with trains operating at speeds of up to 320 km/h, reducing travel time to under three hours.

The project has entered a crucial phase with the commencement of track laying using Japan’s Shinkansen-based J-slab ballastless track system. Under this system, tracks are being installed on viaducts using reinforced concrete (RC) track beds, cement asphalt mortar, precast track slabs, and fastening systems for rails.

Manufacturing of track slabs has started at dedicated facilities in Kim (Surat) and Anand. These precast slabs

are transported via trailers to construction bases for installation. Currently, 10 track construction bases are operational-four in the Surat, Bilimora, and Vapi region, and six in Vadodara, Anand, and Ahmedabad.

So far, around 185 km of RC track bed has been completed, and approximately 188 km worth of track slabs have been produced. Track slab launching and related injection work have been completed across nearly 70 km.

In terms of overall infrastructure, about 347 km of viaduct and 439 km of piers have been constructed. Additionally, 17 river bridges and 13 steel bridges have been completed. Noise barriers exceeding 5.7 lakh units have been installed over a 289 km stretch.As of 2026, more than half of the total project work has been completed, with significant progress observed in Gujarat.

8 killed, 2 injured as vehicle plunges into gorge in Uttarakhand

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Tehri

Eight people died and two others injured when a utility pickup vehicle skidded off the road and fell into a 300-metre deep gorge near Chamba in Tehri district on Thursday, officials said.

The accident occurred around 2.15 pm near Nail village on the Chamba-Koti Colony road.

The victims, all of them from Thyoldhar village in the Ghansali, were returning home from a funeral, when the driver lost control of the vehicle, Tehri District Magistrate Nitika Khandelwal said.

There were around 10 people onboard at the time of the accident. The accident was reported to the police via the Dial 112 emergency service, after which two ambulances and rescue teams were immediately dispatched to the spot. The police and State Disaster



Response Force (SDRF) teams recovered eight bodies and took the injured to a nearby hospital.

The victims were returning home after performing the last rites of 65-year-old Sampat Lal in Haridwar. The deceased were identi-

fied as Sampat Lal’s 36-year-old son, Prem Lal, and 35-year-old driver, Shiv Singh. Others were Asha Lal, 40, Vijay Lal, 36, Mahavir, 60, Sehat Lal, 65, and Laxman, 33. The identity of one more victim was not confirmed. Two

injured are undergoing treatment at the Tehri District Hospital. Chief Medical Superintendent Dr Amit Rai stated their condition is out of danger.

Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami expressed grief over the deaths and

PM CONDOLES DEATHS IN UTTARAKHAND

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the loss of lives in an accident in Tehri Garhwal in Uttarakhand and announced an ex gratia of ₹2 lakh to the next of kin of those killed and Rs 50,000 for the injured. Eight people were killed and two others injured after a pickup vehicle fell into a deep gorge in the Chamba area of the Tehri district. “The loss of lives due to an accident in Tehri Garhwal district of Uttarakhand is saddening. I extend my condolences to those who have lost their loved ones in this mishap.

Farm worker kills employer in Amreli

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amreli

In a shocking incident highlighting the growing obsession with mobile phones and social media, a farm worker allegedly murdered his employer in Gujarat’s Amreli district after being reprimanded for making a reel during work hours.

The incident took place in BarwalaBavishi village of Vadiataluka. According to reports, the accused, Ravi Karoliya, had been working as a farm labourer for the past three years in the farm owned by KaranbhaiVala.

On the day of the incident, Ravi was reportedly making a social media reel while seat on a tractor instead of attending to his work. When Karanbhai objected him for neglecting his duties, the labourer became enraged. In a fit of anger, Ravi allegedly attacked Karanbhai using a stone and a pipe, inflicting fatal injuries.

MEA debunks ‘fake’ passport claims against...

Following the claims, a case was registered against Khara at the Guwahati Crime Branch Police Station under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The charges include Section 175 (false statements in connection with an election) and Section 318 (cheating), among others.

The issue has placed the Congress party under scrutiny, with criticism intensifying over its claims. Union Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita also rejected the allegations, stating that the documents presented were not genuine. Earlier, Speaking to reporters in Jorhat, Margherita said the MEA had verified the matter through diplomatic channels. “The documents, including the passports shown during the press briefing, are false and fabricated,” she said, reiterating that the investigation found no evidence to support the Congress leader’s claims. Meanwhile, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma has initiated legal action against Khara and others over the allegations, further escalating the political row.

West Bengal polls above 90%, TN sees record...

In 2021, the BJP won 59 of these 152 seats against the TMC’s 93. Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulated the people of West Bengal for their massive turnout in the first phase and called the voting figures so far indicative of an “overwhelming mandate for change” as BJP through its high intensity looks forward to wrest power from Mamata Banerjee led TMC in the State.

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee claimed, “From my understanding of people’s mind, we are already in a position to win given the polling held so far today.”

Tamil Nadu surpassed its highest Assembly polls turnout when over 84 per cent of the 5.73 crore voters cast their vote for the single phase elections to 234 constituencies across the State. Incidentally, through the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), the electorate size has been reduced from 6.41 crore recorded in October 2025 to the current 5.73 crore. Consequently, the 2021 polls saw about 6.29 crore people registered, 56 lakh voters more than this year.

Key contenders in Tamil Nadu are the ruling DMK and main opposition AIADMK, while actor-politician Vijay-led TVK and Tamil nationalist Seemant NTK are putting up a determined fight. Attributing the surge in voter turnout in Tamil Nadu to the Election Commission’s reforms, BJP leader Narayanan Thirupathy said the high polling percentage across the state reflects a robust democratic spirit and signals a confident path to victory for the NDA.

Demanding an apology from Gandhi and Stalin for “this downright insult” to the Prime Minister, the Union minister said the Congress and DMK have humiliated 140 crore Indians, including our 8 crore Tamil brothers and sisters, with this statement. Union Minister Piyush Goyal slammed Kharge’s remark on PM Modi and demanded an apology from him. “We feel ashamed that the Congress has come down to such a level. They called a demo-

cratically-elected Prime Minister a terrorist. He has been elected by the people. I strongly condemn Kharge’s statement and demand an apology from him for insulting him and the people of our country,” Goyal, who is the Assembly elections incharge of Tamil Nadu, said.

“This unholy alliance is effectively calling Indians terrorists by targeting the Prime Minister. Such personal attacks against the PM won’t reverse their electoral fate that has already been sealed by the anger of the people who have suffered their misrule,” he added.

BJP IT chief Amit Malviya also took to social media and posted a series of comments to attack the Congress, while BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra said the words Kharge chose for the Prime Minister are not only condemnable but also reflect the mindset of the Congress party. Kharge called him a terrorist.”

Trump makes racist attack on India; MEA...

Despite the restrained official response, the controversy has sparked political reactions domestically. The Indian National Congress condemned the remarks as “extremely insulting and anti-India,” urging Prime Minister Narendra Modi to raise the issue with Washington.

The controversy deepened after Trump also reshared an anti-immigrant post on his platform Truth Social that used derogatory language about India and China, intensifying debate around US citizenship laws. The post criticized birthright citizenship and claimed that immigrant communities undermine cultural integration-assertions widely criticized as misleading and inflammatory.

It further alleged systemic bias in employment and immigration systems, claiming internal mechanisms disproportionately favour individuals from India and China, and argued that the United States has shifted from a “melting pot” to a “cash-in pot.” Trump’s amplification of such rhetoric risks complicating ties between Washington and New Delhi, even as both Governments continue to publicly emphasize the strength of their strategic partnership.

Heavy security keeps West Bengal poll...

Clashes broke out between locals and security personnel in the Kharisaoal area in Birbhum on Thursday after allegations of EVM malfunctioning triggered tension during the final hours of polling. Security personnel, including central forces, intervened to disperse the crowd, following which clashes erupted. Police and CRPF personnel were pelted with stones, prompting them to resort to mild force to bring the situation under control. Several personnel of the central forces were injured in the incident, the officials said. A police vehicle was also damaged during the violence. BJP alleged that its Kumarganj nominee Suvendu Sarkar was manhandled by TMC supporters. Union Minister of State and Balurghat MP Sukanta Majumdar condemned the incident, asserting that “those responsible will be duly punished after the

BJP forms a Government in the state”. Another BJP candidate Agnimitra Paul’s car was pelted with stones and its rear windowpanes were shattered near Rahmat Nagar in her Asansol Dakshin Assembly constituency on Thursday, police said.

Clashes broke out between supporters of the AJUP and TMC in Naoda area in Murshidabad district, prompting police and central forces to resort to baton charge to disperse the mob, officials said. Home Minister Amit Shah and West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee monitored the ground situation from their ‘war rooms’ from Salt Lake and Kalighat respectively. Shah was accompanied by senior BJP leaders, including Union minister Bhupendra Yadav, whereas Mamata was accompanied by her nephew and the party’s general secretary Abhishek Banerjee. The BJP’s Salt Lake office operated a parallel command structure, with Shah personally taking charge. He arrived at the BJP war room soon after polling began, held closed-door meetings with senior leaders, and assessed real-time feedback from constituencies.

Sources said the Union minister reviewed voter turnout patterns, reports of disturbances and inputs from booth-level workers, with a particular focus on north Bengal, a region critical to the BJP’s electoral calculus.

Armed with a dense network of local inputs, the TMC leadership was not just monitoring, but also issuing instructions to district leaders, especially in sensitive pockets, reflecting what insiders described as an “extra layer of vigilance” in a fiercely contested election. As sporadic incidents of violence and allegations of intimidation trickled in through the day, both camps used their respective command centres to calibrate responses - politically and organisationally - in what is shaping up to be one of Bengal’s most closely watched electoral contests.

Tehran hits back at Trump, backs India

India and China are widely regarded as among the world’s oldest continuous civilisations, with cultural and historical traditions stretching back over four millennia. In contrast, the United States, founded in 1776, is approaching its 250th year of independence.

Iran’s statement appeared aimed at countering Trump’s characterisation by highlighting the deep historical legacies of the two Asian nations.

The controversy stems from a letter shared by Trump that criticises birthright citizenship in the United States-a long-standing and contentious political issue. The post alleges that immigrants exploit American systems, claiming that children born on US soil automatically gain citizenship and can later sponsor family members for immigration. Trump’s remarks, and the amplification of such rhetoric, have drawn criticism from multiple quarters and risk further straining diplomatic sensitivities. Iran’s intervention underscores how the controversy has extended beyond US domestic politics into the realm of international relations, drawing responses from countries with strategic and historical stakes in the narrative.

US escalates Strait of Hormuz crisis with kill...

“We will continue global maritime enforcement to disrupt illicit networks and interdict vessels providing material support to Iran, wherever they operate,” a Pentagon statement said.

Ship-tracking data showed the Majestic X in the Indian Ocean between Sri Lanka and Indonesia, roughly the same location as the oil tanker Tifani, earlier seized by American forces. It had been bound for Zhoushan, China.

The vessel previously had been named Phonix and had been sanctioned by the US Treasury Department in 2024 for smuggling Iranian crude oil in contravention of US sanctions on the Islamic Republic.

There was no immediate response from Iran on the news of the seizure.

Since the February 28 start of the war between Iran, Israel and the United States, over 30 ships have come under attack in the waters of the Persian Gulf, the Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman. The threat of attack, rising insurance premiums and other fears have stopped traffic from moving through the strait. Iran’s ability to restrict traffic through the strait, which leads from the Persian Gulf to the open ocean, has proved a major strategic advantage.

Trump this week extended a ceasefire to give the battered Iranian leadership more time to come with a “unified proposal” on ending the war, while maintaining an American blockade of Iranian ports. There was no immediate sign whether peace talks, previously hosted by Pakistan, would resume anytime soon.

Trump, in a separate post on Thursday, claimed a leadership rift between moderates and hardliners was confounding Iran.

“Iran is having a very hard time figuring out who their leader is! They just don’t know!” Trump said. Trump has repeatedly said over the course of the ceasefire that began on April 8 that his team is dealing with Iranian officials who want to make a deal, while acknowledging his decision to kill several top leaders has come with some complications.

The ceasefire has been strained by duelling US attacks on Iranian ships and those by Iran on commercial vessels. It also remains unclear when, or if, the two sides will meet again in the Pakistani capital Islamabad, where officials say they are still trying to bring the countries together to reach a diplomatic deal.

The conflict already has sent gas prices skyrocketing far beyond the region and raised the cost of food and a wide array of other products. Officials around the world have warned the impact to businesses, consumers and economies could be long-lasting.

J&K: 4 OGWs arrested

The police has already launched thorough investigations and interrogated them to uncover any terror plot being hatched by the terrorist handlers of some of the Pakistan-based terror outfits active in the Kashmir valley.

A case has been registered under FIR No. 20/2026 at Police Station Ahmad Nagar under

relevant provisions of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and the Arms Act. Officials added that further investigation into the matter is currently underway.

Meanwhile, tourist traffic to the Kashmir valley is likely to increase with the launch of the Vande Bharat Train services between Jammu and Srinagar via Katra from April 30. According to official sources, over 7.6 lakh tourists visited Pahalgam following the brutal terror attack. Tourist arrivals have steadily increased over the past few months. Between March 15 and April 15, 2026, 1.38 lakh tourists visited Pahalgam.

Police probe premeditation in south...

During questioning, Meena reportedly told investigators that he had gone to the house to get money. He said the crime would not have happened if the victim had given him cash. Police sources said he showed little remorse during interrogation.

According to the police, after he reached the house, he went directly to the terrace study room, where the victim was preparing for the civil services examination. When questioned about his presence, he told her that her mother had called him for some work.

Police said he then demanded money. When the woman refused, an argument broke out. Investigators said Meena attacked her with a lamp and another heavy object, causing injuries to her face and head. He then strangled her using a mobile phone charging cable. According to the probe, he raped her while she was unconscious.

After the assault, Meena attempted to open a locker in the house. Police said he dragged the woman from the study room to another room where the locker was located. He tried to unlock it using her fingerprint on a biometric scanner, but it did not work. Investigators believe she may have died by then, which could explain why the scanner failed to recognise her fingerprint. He then used a screwdriver to break open the locker and took cash and jewellery. Police said he packed the items in a bag found in the house. Before leaving, he changed out of his blood-stained clothes and wore trousers belonging to the victim’s brother. He also changed his footwear to avoid suspicion.

Meena, whose face was covered with a cloth, was produced in the jam-packed courtroom around 2.30 pm on Thursday. “*Mujhse apradh ho gaya... Galti ho gayi*,” (I committed a crime, a mistake), said Rahul Meena, as a city court sent him to four days of police custody.

The victim, an engineering graduate, had studied at a leading Delhi school and later graduated from a premier institute. She was preparing for the civil services examination and had recently begun a new study routine, starting early in the morning. Her parents found her when they returned from the gym around 8 am. She was taken to the hospital, where she was declared dead. A postmortem confirmed death due to strangulation, along with multiple injuries.

Rajnath invites German firms to co-develop tech in India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday invited the German industry to co-develop and co-produce with India, particularly in the field of niche technologies, as he underscored the need to forge partnerships based on reliability and shared interests.

He termed them as indispensable in the current shifts in geopolitical alignments, disruptions in supply chains, rapid technological transformations, and increasing global uncertainties while addressing Indian and German Defence Industry leaders during the Defence Investor Summit in Munich, the defence ministry here said. The minister was in Germany on a three-day visit ending Thursday. It was his

maiden visit there as the defence minister.

Rajnath Singh asserted that nations and industries are re-evaluating their dependencies, diversifying their supply chains, and seeking reliable partners who ensure resilience, continuity and mutual trust.

He Stated that India, in this scenario, offers an expanding market, young and skilled workforce, and a rapidly evolving industrial ecosystem, coupled with stability, predictability, and a commitment to the rule of law. These are the critical factors for long-term investment decisions in an uncertain world, the defence minister said.

Referring to the significant untapped potential under the ReArm Europe and Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiatives, Rajnath Singh reiterated



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh addressing the Defence Investor Summit in Munich, Germany

ed that Indian companies are keen to engage with German companies for co-development and co-production in areas including advanced radar and sensor technology, multi-sensors, AI-enabled Unmanned Aerial Systems, Sonobouys and High

Power Low Frequency Underwater Transmitters.

Rajnath Singh described India's pursuit of self-reliance as not inward-looking, but about opening new pathways of partnership.

He pointed out that India recognises the significant

role of the defence sector in the journey towards becoming a developed nation, and has placed it at the heart of its industrial and technological strategy.

The defence minister told the German industry captains that the Government of India, over the past decade, has undertaken a series of structural reforms to improve the ease of doing business and make India an attractive destination for investment.

Rajnath Singh appreciated the deepening of India-Germany defence relations through significant industrial partnerships, with a growing focus on co-development and co-production. "Both nations are aligning their industries to create resilient supply chains for defence equipment, particularly in response to geopolitical shifts," he said.

On April 22, Rajnath Singh visited the TKMS Submarine building facility in Kiel, underscoring the deepening defence engagement between India and Germany. The visit provided an opportunity to exchange views on advanced maritime capabilities and explore avenues for collaboration in naval technologies, in line with India's defence modernisation priorities.

Earlier, Rajnath Singh held bilateral talks with his German counterpart Boris Pistorius in Berlin, aimed at further strengthening the strategic defence partnership with the European nation. The Defence Industrial Cooperation Roadmap and Implementing Arrangement for Cooperation in UN Peacekeeping Training were inked and exchanged during the meeting.

States Focus



Envoys of 4 nations present credentials to President

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday accepted credentials from envoys of four nations, including Congo and Namibia, at a ceremony held at Rashtrapati Bhavan here, her office said. Those who presented their credentials were Vithaya Xayavong, Ambassador of the Lao People's Democratic Republic, Emilie Ayaza Mushobekwa, Ambassador of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Wing Commander Alex Lunyazo Tukuhupwele (Retd), High Commissioner of the Republic of Namibia and Antonio Serifo Embalo, Ambassador of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau, it said in a Statement.



Naidu kicks off ₹5,400 cr solar plant in Anakapalli

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Thursday laid the foundation for a ₹5,400-crore ReNew solar manufacturing facility here. The 6 GW solar ingot and wafer manufacturing unit at Rambilli in Anakapalli district is expected to be a key step toward building a resilient domestic solar supply chain, an official press release said earlier. Addressing a public meeting, he said, "Anakapalli district is attracting development through big-ticket investments. It will reach the top position in investments in India ReNew is setting up a 6.5 GW ingot solar wafer plant at an investment of ₹5,400 crore." According to the CM, the solar manufacturing unit is being established by the son of former Union Minister Yashwanth Sinha and Sumanth Sinha.

CBSE class-10 second board exams begin may 15

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Thursday announced the schedule for the second board examinations for Class-10, to be held from May 15 to May 21.

According to the datesheet issued by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), the examination cycle will begin with the mathematics (standard and basic) paper on May 15, followed by English (communicative) and English (language and literature) on May 16. The science examination will be conducted on May 18.

A cluster of language and elective subjects, including Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi, Bangla, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Gujarati and several foreign languages, has been scheduled for May 19. The other subjects lined up on the same



day include home science and select vocational courses.

On May 20, students will appear for Sanskrit, painting, information technology and artificial intelligence papers, followed by social science, the last exam, on May 21. The datesheet was issued by the controller of examinations, Sanyam Bhardwaj, a week after the CBSE declared the results of the first edition

of the Class-10 board exams.

Starting 2026, the CBSE is holding Class-10 board exams twice a year. The first one in February was mandatory, while the second, which is optional, will be held in May for improvement or clearing failed subjects.

Students can take up to three subjects in the second exam and retain their best score, according to the CBSE.

Navy Chief Admiral: Boost forces' coordination for Indo-Pacific security

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sri Vijaya Puram

Navy chief Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi stressed the importance of coordination and interoperability among the Army, Navy, Air Force and Coast Guard to address emerging security challenges in the Indo-Pacific.

Admiral Tripathi was on a two-day visit to the Andaman and Nicobar Command (ANC), during which he reviewed the operational preparedness and discussed measures to strengthen jointmanship and enhance synergy among the services.

During the visit from April 21 to 22, Admiral Tripathi held detailed interactions with senior officers and was briefed on ongoing operational activities and initiatives, officials said on



Thursday. Discussions focused on strengthening operational synergy, improving readiness and deepening integration among the services, they said.

Highlighting the strategic significance of the islands, Admiral Tripathi reiterated the pivotal role of ANC in ensuring maritime security, enhancing surveillance and maintaining rapid response capability in the region, particularly given its proximity to critical sea lanes of com-

munication.

He also interacted with personnel and commended their professionalism, dedication and high State of operational readiness in safeguarding the nation's maritime frontiers.

Earlier in January, Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan visited the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and inaugurated the upgraded runway at the Indian Air Force's Car Nicobar air base.

India, Egypt review defence ties, focus on joint production and technology

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Egypt reviewed the entire spectrum of their defence ties with a focus on promoting collaboration in defence production and technology, besides strengthening joint training exchanges during the 11th India-Egypt Joint Defence Committee (JDC) meeting in Cairo on April 20-22, defence ministry said here on Thursday.

The Indian delegation was led by Joint Secretary (International Cooperation) Amitabh Prasad and included senior representatives from the Ministry of Defence and the Defence Forces. The Egyptian delegation was



headed by senior officials of the Defence Forces and the Ministry of Defence.

Both sides undertook a comprehensive review of the progress made since the previous JDC meeting and charted out a forward-looking roadmap for defence engagement.

They agreed on a bilateral defence cooperation plan

2026-27 focusing on expanding structured military interaction mechanisms, strengthening joint training exchanges, enhancing maritime security cooperation, increasing scope and complexity of military exercises and promoting collaboration in defence production and technology.

The Indian delegation

made a presentation on fast growing manufacturing capabilities of the Indian defence industry, highlighting the fact that its production has crossed US \$20 billion and India is exporting products valuing around US \$4 billion to over 100 countries. The two sides agreed to work together to develop a defence industry cooperation plan. The defence industry collaboration is emerging as a key pillar of India-Egypt defence ties with both sides exploring opportunities for co-development and co-production in the field of defence manufacturing.

The inaugural Navy-to-Navy Staff Talks were held on the sidelines of the meeting. The stellar role

played by the Indian Navy in promoting freedom of navigation in the Indian Ocean region was presented and the key role played by India's Information Fusion Centre in promoting maritime security was highlighted.

The Indian delegation also called on the Commander of the Egyptian Air Force (EAF) Lieutenant General Amr Abdel Rahman Saqr. The delegation thanked the EAF Commander for the close cooperation between the Air Forces of the two countries.

The Indian delegation also laid a wreath at the HeliPolis War Memorial and paid homage to Indian Bravehearts who made the supreme sacrifice during World War I and II.

TMC set to win West Bengal, will 'conquer Delhi' next: Mamata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday asserted that polling held so far in the first phase of the assembly polls indicates the TMC is already in a position to win.

Banerjee, also the Trinamool Congress supremo, said at a rally in Bow Bazar area of Kolkata that she will conquer Delhi taking along all Opposition parties, after winning the election.

A voter turnout of 89.93 per cent was recorded till 5 pm, as polling was underway in



152 of the 294 assembly seats in phase I. The next round will take place on April 29, while counting will be held on May 4. "From my understanding of people's mind, we are already in a position to win given the polling held so far today," Banerjee said.

"I am not interested in any post, I don't want the chair. I only want the end of BJP Government in Delhi," she said.

Earlier, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, speaking at a rally in Krishnanagar, congratulated the people of West Bengal for the massive turnout in the first phase of the polls, terming it an "overwhelming mandate for change".

Banerjee, however, asserted that people voted in good numbers to protest the deletion of names in the SIR exercise, claiming that her efforts led to inclusion of 32 lakh names in the voter list.

Security lapse in Balotra: Man enters VVIP stage before PM event

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Raising serious questions about security preparedness for the Prime Minister Narendra Modi's event in Rajasthan's Balotra district, which was later postponed, a man allegedly managed to access the VVIP stage at the venue on the eve of the programme.

The person has been identified as Arshad. He was booked under relevant sections of Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and later released, officials said on Thursday.



A station house officer (SHO) has been suspended in connection with the incident. PM Modi was scheduled to visit the place on April 21 to inaugurate HPCL Pachpadra refinery, but the visit was postponed following a fire

incident at the refinery.

Arshad allegedly entered the restricted 'D' area, accessed the stage and recorded a video, which he later surfaced on social media.

Terming it a grave lapse, officials said preventing unauthorised access to the VVIP stage is the responsibility of personnel on duty, and any negligence would invite strict action.

Consequently, Pachpadra police station SHO, Achala Ram, has been suspended, Jodhpur Range Inspector General of Police Satyendra Singh told reporters.

"After the fire incident at the

refinery, a man identified as Arshad climbed onto the stage at the event site and recorded a video, which he later made viral. This is a serious security lapse," Singh said.

He added that the Rajasthan Armed Constabulary (RAC) Commandant has been directed to identify the personnel responsible and initiate strict disciplinary action against them.

Preliminary investigation indicates negligence on the part of RAC personnel deployed at the venue, who failed to prevent the youth from reaching the stage, the officials said.

Rahul Gandhi an immature politician: Nitin Nabin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Thursday called Rahul Gandhi an "immature politician", and claimed that the way the Congress leader behaves and speaks reflects his improper political growth.

In an interview with News18 Network, Nabin also alleged that Gandhi functions with an "anarchist mindset" and does not understand the "gravity of things".

"The leader of the Opposition (in Lok Sabha) is part of the Government. But look at his activities, working

and language, both inside and outside Parliament. Does a leader of Opposition, that too from a national party, speak in such a manner?" Nabin said.

"I believe that Rahul Gandhi is an immature politician, whose political growth, in some way, has not been proper," he added.

Asked about Mallikarjun Kharge's recent 'terrorist' jibe targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Nabin said the Congress president is "helpless" and uses words that Gandhi's PR agency asks him to use.

"I would say that whatever words Rahul Ji's inner circle



and his PR agency suggest to him, 'bechare' (helpless) Kharge ji keeps repeating them," Nabin alleged.

He also said the Congress has been insulting Prime Minister Modi for a long time due to its "petty mindset", and Kharge appears to be emerging as the

torchbearer of the tradition established by his party.

"The people of the country have been punishing the Congress for this, but it is yet to learn its lesson," the BJP president said.

Kharge on Tuesday accused Modi of "terrorising" political parties by misusing Government machinery and central agencies to stifle the Opposition.

Addressing a press conference in Chennai, Kharge initially referred to Modi as a "terrorist" before saying that he meant that the prime minister was "terrorising" the democratic fabric of the country.

Arunachal eyes tourism hub at Subansiri Lower Dam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

The Arunachal Pradesh Government has unveiled an ambitious plan to develop the Subansiri Lower pondage into a world-class mountaintum-cum-river tourism hub, aiming to integrate ecotourism, adventure, culture and sustainable livelihoods while leveraging the State's hydropower infrastructure. The proposed hub will



come up around the 2,000 MW Subansiri Lower Hydroelectric Project, India's largest hydroelectric project, which is slated for full commissioning by December this

year, with four units already operational.

The pondage created by the project is being viewed as a unique opportunity to build a high-value tourism ecosystem in one of the country's most biodiverse river corridors, an official communique informed here on Thursday.

Pondage is the storage of water in a small, regulated reservoir or pond located immediately at a hydropower plant.

NCB to Indians: Be vigilant in Maldives as drug laws include death penalty

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) on Thursday cautioned Indians planning a visit to the Maldives to remain extremely vigilant about their belongings as the island country has strengthened its anti-drug laws, including harsh punishments like the death penalty in extreme cases.

"Be aware that ignorance of the law is not a defence and any legal violations may result in severe punish-



ments," the federal anti-narcotics agency said. The advisory comes after the Maldives recently "strengthened" its anti-narcotics laws by amending the Maldives' Drugs Act, effective March 2026. The NCB said the

amendments prescribe significantly-enhanced penalties for drug-related offences, including life imprisonment and, in certain cases involving large-scale trafficking, the death penalty, subject to confirmation by a competent

court under Maldivian laws. The amended law provides stricter punishment even for possessing small quantities of prohibited substances, it said.

The High Commission of India in the Maldives has also issued advisories urging Indian nationals to strictly comply with local laws and regulations, it said. The NCB "strongly" advises Indians to exercise "extreme" caution at all ports and transit points when unknown individuals request that they carry goods.

Indian passengers should not carry any package, baggage or item on behalf of others under any circumstances, without being absolutely sure of the contents, it said.

"Maintain full control and supervision of (your) personal baggage at all times," the NCB said.

The agency added that recent instances have been reported involving the arrests of foreign nationals, including Indian citizens, in the Maldives for drug-related offences.

States Focus



ETTAYAPURAM VILLAGERS BOYCOTT POLLS OVER PATHWAY DISPUTE

In Ettayapuram, famous for revolutionary poet Subramania Bharathi, a different kind of revolt is unfolding. The villagers of Kulathuvaipatti and Kumaragiri of Ettayapuram, which comes under Vilathikulam constituency, have sworn themselves off the polling booth over a "pathway dispute". For many years, the villagers have been fighting with the residents of a Sri Lankan refugee camp in the area over public access to the pathway that cuts across the camp to the agricultural lands. The tension reached a breaking point on April 18, when a stone-pelting clash left the community scarred and the path further obstructed.



PM MODI APPEALS FOR RECORD TURNOUT IN TN, WB ELECTIONS

The Tamil Nadu Assembly election on Thursday turned out to be a kaleidoscope of tidbits, tense moments and curiosity. Incidents like AIADMK leader and former Minister Dindigul C Srinivasan reportedly pressing the 'red light' on the Electronic Voting Machine (EVM) instead of the button to cast vote amused people. Later, the polling official pointed to the button and he cast his vote. Polling was on across 234 Assembly segments in the State with over 4,000 candidates in fray. In Coimbatore, Vellore and Dharmapuri districts, 'Robo Tina', dressed like a cute little girl welcomed voters to the polling station and gave flowers and chocolates to the people. Some, working in foreign countries including Singapore and in cities outside of Tamil Nadu arrived in their hometowns including Chennai to cast their votes.

West Bengal: High voter turnout signals mandate for change, says PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Krishnagar

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday congratulated the people of West Bengal for their massive turnout in the ongoing first phase of assembly elections, and called the vote figures so far indicative of an "overwhelming mandate for change".

Addressing a poll rally in Krishnagar in Nadia district, Modi also congratulated the Election Commission for keeping "violence during the assembly polls in the State at a minimum".

"This is the first time in the last 50 years of poll history in Bengal that incidents of violence were kept at a minimum. The information I have received so far about the record-breaking turnout makes me certain that this is going to be an overwhelming mandate in favour of a change which Bengal's voters have already decided to bring



PM Narendra Modi greeting supporters during a roadshow in support of BJP candidates amid the ongoing West Bengal Assembly elections in Howrah district on Thursday

about," the PM said. Referring to the voter turnout figures elsewhere in the country, the PM claimed the BJP achieved decisive victories whenever people turned up to vote in massive numbers.

Bengal has recorded an average voter turnout of nearly 90 per cent till 5 pm.

Reports of sporadic violence were received from some pockets of the State during the first half of polls taking place across 152 assem-

I had jhalmuri, but it seems that the TMC leaders are feeling heat of the chillies

— PM NARENDRA MODI

bly seats amid unprecedented security arrangements, where over 2400 companies of central paramilitary troops have been deployed.

Modi said that the BJP's

Bengal unit would hold victory celebrations on May 4 after the counting of votes gets over where the party would distribute among people not just sweets, but also 'jhalmuri', the popular street snack which the PM savoured at an unscheduled stop during his visit to Jhargram last week.

Referring to that incident, Modi took a dig at TMC leaders after Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee termed the PM's extended stay as "drama" and claimed that "the entire episode was scripted".

"I have heard that even jhalmuri has given certain individuals a thunderous jolt," the PM said, "I had 'jhalmuri', but it seems that the TMC leaders are feeling heat of the chillies."

Referring to "people's disgust with TMC's syndicate, criminal and Mafia nexus", Modi claimed that the party will not win even a single seat in certain districts of the State.

AJUP and TMC supporters clash in Murshidabad; forces use baton charge

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Naoda (West Bengal)

Clashes broke out between supporters of the Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP) and the ruling TMC in Naoda area in West Bengal's Murshidabad district on Thursday, prompting police and central forces to resort to baton charge to disperse the mob, officials said.

The violence was reported from Shibnagar village in the Naoda assembly constituency during the first phase of the State assembly polls. Several incidents of vehicle vandalism were reported. Workers of Humayun Kabir's (AJUP) were

accused of being involved in the disturbances, though he denied all the allegations.

Central forces resorted to a lathi charge to bring the situation under control. The Election Commission has sought a report on the incident, the officials said.

Tension had been brewing since the morning when the AJUP chief visited a polling booth in the area after casting his vote.

Kabir was greeted with protests by TMC supporters, who raised "go back" slogans and surrounded his vehicle, branding him a "BJP agent".

The situation turned tense, with heated exchanges



taking place between the two sides near the polling station.

The AJUP leader later staged a sit-in at the spot and accused the ruling party of intimidating voters and being involved in electoral malpractices.

Kabir also alleged that the

TMC had bribed several of his party candidates to keep them out of the poll fray, a charge the ruling party did not immediately respond to.

The officials said the situation escalated later in the day when clashes broke out between supporters of the two parties.

Mamata, Shah run rival 'war rooms' as West Bengal votes in phase 1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

As Bengal voted in phase one across 152 seats on Thursday, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and Union Home Minister Amit Shah steered rival 'war rooms' from Kalighat and Salt Lake, tracking real-time turnout and booth-level feedback in a high-stakes electoral battle.

Banerjee was accompanied by her nephew and party's general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, whereas Shah was accompanied by senior BJP leaders, including Union minister Bhupendra Yadav.

Sporadic violence, intimi-

dation and assaults on BJP candidates cast a shadow over polling in several pockets, as West Bengal recorded brisk voting in the first phase of the assembly elections on Thursday, with turnout climbing to 78.77 per cent of 3.60 crore electors by 3 pm. From early morning, Kalighat, the ruling TMC's political nerve centre, became a virtual command hub. Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee closely monitored polling trends, district feedback, and any signs of disruption, party sources said.

Armed with a dense network of local inputs, the TMC leadership was not just



monitoring, but also issuing instructions to district leaders, especially in sensitive pockets, reflecting what insiders described as an "extra layer of vigilance" in a fiercely contested election.

The heightened alertness comes against the backdrop of Banerjee's repeated public warnings during the campaign about alleged EVM manipulation, with the chief minister urging voters to

reject malfunctioning machines and remain watchful against any attempt at electoral malpractice.

If Kalighat was the TMC's traditional nerve centre, the BJP's Salt Lake office mirrored a parallel command structure – one that saw Shah himself step in as the day's political tempo built up.

In a move that underscored the central leadership's tight grip on the Bengal battle, Shah arrived at the BJP's 'war room' shortly after polling began, holding closed-door deliberations with senior leaders and taking stock of real-time feedback from across constituencies.

No intruder will enter Bengal under BJP rule, says Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Balagarh (West Bengal)

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said "not a single intruder" would be allowed to enter West Bengal if the BJP comes to power in the State, and the illegal immigrants already here would be "selectively rooted out".

Addressing a public rally at Balagarh in Hooghly district on a day when voting for the first phase was underway, he said the BJP was poised to form a Government in the State with a full majority.

"Today, the voting for the first phase is almost over, and this is my 30th programme across Bengal. On May 5, Didi's game will be up. The BJP will form a Government in Bengal with a full majority," he said.

The result of the West Bengal Assembly polls will be declared on May 4. Asserting that infiltration was hurting the State's economy and national security, Shah said, "Intruders are eating away the jobs of Bengal's youth, the rations of the poor, and working to undermine the country's security."

Stepping up his attack on the TMC Government, the



senior BJP leader accused it of fostering "syndicate raj" and burdening people with what he described as "Bhaipo tax", in a jibe at Mamata Banerjee's nephew and the TMC's national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee.

"Bengalis have to pay 'Bhaipo' tax to the TMC's syndicate. Even to purchase cement, people are forced to pay. Say 'ta ta-bye-bye' to the Mamata Government, and we will straighten up the syndicate operators," he said. Shah also flagged the alleged decline of Balagarh's traditional boat-making industry, claiming that it had suffered under the present dispensation.

"Balagarh's boat industry once provided employment to the entire region. But due to Mamata's syndicate raj, it has shut down. Around 41

factories have been closed. I assure you that once the BJP forms the Government, we will restart these units," he said.

Invoking Bengal's legacy, Shah paid tribute to educationist Ashutosh Mukherjee and Syama Prasad Mookerjee, the founder of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, the BJP's ideological predecessor.

"This is the land of Ashutosh Mukherjee, who had earned the moniker 'Tiger of Bengal'. His son, Syama Prasad Mookerjee, founded our party and sacrificed his life for the nation. I pay my respects to both leaders," he said.

In a sharp political pitch ahead of the next phase of polling, Shah urged voters to back the BJP, framing the contest as one linked to identity and security.

KUMARGANJ CANDIDATE MANHANDLED BY TMC: BJP



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kumarganj (WB)

The BJP on Thursday alleged that its Kumarganj nominee Suwendu Sarkar was manhandled by Trinamool Congress supporters during polling in the first phase of the West Bengal assembly elections.

Sarkar was beaten up while he was going to a polling booth in the constituency after he came to know about chaos allegedly created by TMC activists near the voting centre.

The saffron party candidate was, however, attacked when he was walking to the school premises where the polling booth was set up, a local BJP leader said.

Sarkar, who had to run through the field with a lone security personnel to save himself, later told reporters that he was surrounded by goons and beaten up.

"I did not see any central force personnel during the incident," he said.

Top leaders, celebrities among early voters in TN polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Top leaders and celebrities were among the early birds who turned up to cast their votes in their respective constituencies on Thursday. Voting for the Tamil Nadu Assembly election across 234 segments commenced at 7 am.

While Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin, Deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin, TVK chief Vijay, AMMK chief TVT Dhinakaran voted in Chennai,



Actor Dhanush shows his ink-marked finger after casting a vote in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections at a polling station in Chennai

AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami voted in Salem. MDMK founder Vaiko and his

son Durai Vaiko voted in Kaligapatti in Tenkasi district. Senior Congress leader P

Congress high command discourages CM debate before Kerala results: Ajay Mohan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thrissur (Kerala)

Congress leader and UDF candidate from the Kunnamkulam Assembly constituency, PT Ajay Mohan, on Thursday said the party high command has discouraged discussions on who should be the CM before the Assembly poll results, which are expected on May 4. Kerala went to the polls on April 9.

Mohan disapproved of discussions on social media about who should become CM if the UDF comes to power, stating that such talks before the declaration



of results are "unnecessary and inappropriate."

"It is for the high command to decide that. I have a soft corner for Ramesh Chennithala, who is a very senior leader in the party and worked with Oommen Chandy. But I cannot say he should be

made the Chief Minister. That would not be appropriate," Mohan told a TV channel here.

He said that such discussions could adversely affect the morale of Congress and UDF workers, as well as the general public.

The high command has discouraged such discussions, he reiterated.

His remarks on the chief ministerial issue come amid a social media campaign in favour of Chennithala, Leader of the Opposition in the State Assembly, VD Satheesan, and Congress General Secretary KC Venugopal.

Karnataka BJP protests against Kharge's 'terrorist' remark on PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka BJP on Thursday staged a protest in front of the Mahatma Gandhi statue at Vidhana Soudha, condemning AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge's "terrorist" remark against Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and demanded that he apologise to the country.

The protest was led by State BJP President B Y Vijayendra, Leaders of Opposition in the Assembly and Council R Ashoka and Chalavadi Narayanaswamy, Union Minister Shobha Karandlaje, and several party legislators and leaders. Holding placards, they



Leader of Opposition in the Karnataka Assembly R Ashok, State BJP President BY Vijayendra and others stage a protest against Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge for his 'terrorist' remark for Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru on Thursday

shouted slogans against Kharge.

"Several countries have conferred their highest civilian awards on our Prime Minister Narendra Modi. No other PM of India has received awards on such a

scale. At a time when the whole world has recognised Narendra Modi's leadership, AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge has made a statement calling him a terrorist. Not only the BJP, but the entire country condemns

it," Vijayendra said. Speaking to reporters, he added that Kharge and the Congress party are probably unable to accept Narendra Modi's popularity.

"Narendra Modi, who comes from a backward class, has successfully led the country as PM for twelve consecutive years. The Congress is unable to accept this. The party is collapsing day by day across the country, so they are making such remarks against Modi. We strongly condemn this and urge Kharge to apologise to the nation," he said.

Ashoka said the AICC president's statement reflects the Congress party's "degraded culture."

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Supreme Court stays life term verdict against Amit Jogi



The Supreme Court on Thursday stayed the Chhattisgarh High Court verdict which had handed down life imprisonment to Amit Jogi, son of former chief minister Ajit Jogi, in the 2003 murder case of NCP leader Ramavatar Jaggi.

The High Court recently convicted Jogi in the case and directed him to surrender before jail authorities. On May 31, 2007, a trial court held that the prosecution had successfully proved the charges against 28 accused. It, however, acquitted Amit Jogi, the president of the Janata Congress Chhattisgarh (J), founded by his late father, of the charges levelled against him.

A bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi took note of the submissions of senior advocates Vivek Tankha and Kapil Sibal, appearing for Jogi, while staying his conviction and the sentence in the case. Senior advocates Sidhharth Luthra and Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for the victim's family member, opposed the submission.

While staying the HC verdict, the top court also issued a notice to the CBI on the plea of Jogi.

Jogi had moved the top court against the High Court verdict. The HC had reopened proceedings in the 2003 murder case last month following directions from the Supreme Court on an appeal by the CBI.

After 18 years of trial, UP man gets 10-year jail, ₹10 lakh fine for drug possession



A court here has sentenced a man to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment along with a fine of ₹1 lakh in a 2008 case related to possession of charas, an official said.

Assistant District Government Counsel Deepak Tiwari said the accused, Sanjay Singh, originally a resident of Kalyanpur in Kanpur and currently residing in Mahaveeran locality, was arrested on April 2, 2008, by then Premnagar police station in-charge Balbir Singh Gaur during a checking drive.

Police had recovered 300 grams of charas (hashish) from his possession and sent him to jail, he said, adding that several criminal cases, including chain snatching and robbery, were also registered against him at various police stations.

Additional District and Sessions Judge Sharad Chaudhary on Wednesday found the accused guilty under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and awarded him 10 years of rigorous imprisonment along with a fine of ₹1 lakh, Tiwari said.

Allahabad HC flags shortage of ventilators

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

A Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court on Wednesday raised serious concerns over the shortage of ventilators in hospitals, observing that statistical claims hold little value if critical care equipment is not accessible to patients in time.

Hearing a PIL, a division bench of Justices Rajan Roy and Manjive Shukla questioned whether any hospital could state on affidavit that a ventilator would be provided promptly whenever required.

The court remarked that if such assurance cannot be given, the data submitted on ventilator availability becomes meaningless.

The bench stressed that the focus should be on ensuring adequate availability of ventilators so that no life is lost due to their shortage.

It expressed dissatisfaction with the figures placed before it, noting that there was an apparent absence of



a mechanism to assess actual demand and determine the number of ventilators required for life-saving treatment.

The court asked the state Government to clarify the proportion of the state budget allocated to healthcare and provide details regarding the status of medical infrastructure.

It also directed the state to revisit its approach and not remain satisfied with merely meeting the minimum norms prescribed by the National Medical Commission (NMC), such as maintaining ventilators equivalent to 10-15 per cent of hospital beds.



PIL against Kejriwal: Court directs removal of clips

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday sought the stand of AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and Sanjay Singh, Congress leader Digvijay Singh and others on a PIL seeking contempt action against them for allegedly uploading and sharing clips of court hearing on the former chief minister's plea seeking recusal of Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma in the liquor policy case.

A bench of justices V Kameswar Rao and Manmeet PS Arora issued notice to them on the petition by advocate Vaibhav Singh and directed social media platforms to take down the videos of the April 13 hearing, as unauthorised recording and sharing of court proceedings are prohibited under the High Court rules.

Counsel for Meta Platforms and Google said the offending links flagged by the petitioner in his plea have been taken

down. Noting that certain videos allegedly showing the April 13 proceedings were available on X, it directed, "If that be so, respondent no 4 (X) shall take down those links" immediately upon receipt of notice.

The court granted the petitioner liberty to approach the counsel for the social media platforms if he finds any other video clips of the proceedings, which would then be removed by them.

"We issue notice to respondent no. 4 and other respondents. The affidavit shall be filed in four weeks," the court said. The other respondents include AAP leaders Sanjeev Jha, Mukesh Ahlawat, Jarnail Singh and journalist Ravish Kumar.

Listing the matter for hearing on July 6, the court also issued notice to the Union Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology and sought its appearance in the matter. During the hearing, the bench said that unauthorised recording,



uploading and publishing of court hearings is prohibited under the High Court rules and asked the social media platforms if they could ensure the removal of such content after it was uploaded.

"We are concerned with the larger interest of the institution. Otherwise, if we don't control this, it would go (on)," the court remarked.

Counsel appearing for Meta Platforms stated that as an intermediary, it neither functions as a "super censor" nor

does it have the technology to proactively monitor appearance of specific content but acts when an issue is escalated as per the law.

"The moment we get to know, we take it down. The moment we got the letter (in this case from the High Court administration), we took it down," the senior counsel for Meta said, adding that no case for initiating contempt action against the platform was established.

The court also asked the

Respect all views except Whatsapp University: SC in Sabarimala case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday said it respects the views of all eminent authors and thinkers, but it cannot accept information from 'WhatsApp University'.

The observation by a nine-judge Constitution bench came while hearing petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala Temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of religious freedom practised by multiple faiths.

The bench was composed of Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan, and Joymalya Bagchi. Senior advocate Neeraj Kishan Kaul, appearing for the head of the Dawoodi



Bohra community, referred to an article written by Congress leader Shashi Tharoor, which talked about judicial restraint in matters of religious relief.

At this juncture, CJI Kant said, "We respect all eminent persons, jurists, etc., but personal opinion is personal opinion." Kaul said there was no harm in drawing from all sources. "If knowledge and wisdom come from any source, any country, any university, it should be welcomed.

We are far too rich as a civilisation not to accept all forms of knowledge and information," Kaul said. Justice Nagarathna, in a lighter vein, said, "But not from WhatsApp University."

Kaul said he was not getting into that. "I am not into which university is good or bad, which is really inconsequential to this debate.... The point is simply that wherever knowledge and information come from, they must be accepted," Kaul said.

I-PAC director sent to 14-day judicial custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Thursday sent political consultancy firm I-PAC co-founder and director Vinesh Chandel to 14-day judicial custody in a money laundering case linked to an alleged coal scam in West Bengal.

Additional Sessions Judge Deepti Devesh allowed the Enforcement Directorate's plea seeking the accused's judicial custody.

He was produced on completion of his 10-day ED custody.

On April 14, the court had allowed the federal agency to quiz Chandel in its custody for 10 days, saying there are reasons to believe that he was actively involved in processes and activities



Vinesh Chandel

connected with the generation, diversion and possession of proceeds of crime worth several crores of rupees.

Days ahead of the West Bengal

Assembly polls, the ED arrested Chandel on April 13 after questioning in the case. Chandel, a law graduate, is a 33 per cent shareholder of I-PAC.

High Court tells RBI to exchange man's ₹2 lakh old currency notes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has directed the Reserve Bank of India to exchange demonetised ₹500 notes worth ₹2 lakh that were seized from a man during demonetisation and returned to him after the prescribed period.

In its order on Wednesday, the court's Nagpur bench of Justices Urmila Joshi-Phalke and Nivedita Mehta said the man cannot be held at fault as the notes were seized by the police before the cut-off date and remained in their custody till after the exchange window closed.

The directive to the RBI was passed on a petition filed by one Girish Malani.

"The petitioner cannot be placed in a disadvantageous position on account for an act for which he is not responsible," the court said.

In his petition, Malani said he was travelling towards Mahur with 400 currency notes, each of ₹500 denomination, on December 1, 2016, when police seized the money. His vehicle was

intercepted by a police patrol team in view of the ongoing municipal elections, and the ₹2 lakh cash was seized as a precautionary measure and deposited at the Mahur police station.

The seizure was intimated to the Income Tax department, which later concluded that the money was legitimate and no further action was necessary.

The notes were returned to Malani on December 31, 2026. The Government of India issued a notification on November 8, 2016, declaring currency notes of ₹500 and ₹1,000 as not legal.

The notification permitted citizens to deposit the said currency notes for exchange



in their banks up to December 30, 2016. In January 2017, Malani approached the RBI seeking to exchange the notes. His request was, however, declined.

In his plea, Malani said the money lawfully belonged to him and that he was deprived of the opportunity to deposit the demonetised currency notes and have them exchanged for legal tender.

The plea said that as per the Government notification, currency notes seized by law enforcement agencies on or before December 30, 2016, were permitted to be tendered to the RBI, subject to compliance with certain conditions.



A group of people standing together, possibly related to the court case.



development department of the state Government, the Ayodhya district magistrate and the UPAEVP expressed their inability to commence arguments on Wednesday.

Taking note of this, the bench observed that the matter has been pending for a long time and unwarranted adjournments would not be appropriate.

It directed that if the state or the housing body fails to advance arguments on the next date, they may file written submissions instead. According to the petitions, the land acquisition in

the court in the eyes of the public.

Alleging that Kejriwal and his party members hatched a "conspiracy" and "dirty strategy" to record the court proceedings, the PIL urged that an SIT be formed to investigate the matter and contempt proceedings be initiated against "all respondents who uploaded, reposted, forwarded the recording of court proceedings dated April 13, 2026".

The PIL also prayed for the removal of the content from social media.

On April 15, Singh filed a complaint with the High Court registrar general against the alleged unauthorised recording of court proceedings.

On April 20, Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma refused to recuse herself from hearing the liquor-policy case, saying a litigant cannot be allowed to judge a judge without any material, and judges cannot recuse themselves to satisfy a litigant's unfounded apprehension of bias.

Allahabad HC stays acquisition of land by UPAEVP in Ayodhya



Ayodhya is being carried out under the Uttar Pradesh Awastha Vikas Parishad Act 1965, which provides that acquisition-related benefits should align with the more beneficial provisions available under law.

The petitioners argued that the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 offers significantly higher compensation and additional safeguards such as rehabilitation, resettlement and social impact assessment.

Court sends 'godman' Kharat to judicial custody till May 6

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nashik

A court in Nashik on Thursday sent self-styled godman Ashok Kharat to judicial custody till May 6 in the fifth case of sexual assault and exploitation registered against him.

Kharat, who was arrested on March 18 after a 35-year-old woman lodged a rape complaint against him at Sarkarwada police station here, has since been accused of sexually

and Ahilyanagar districts, including eight for sexual assault. On April 18, the SIT had sought his custody in the fifth case.

After the court granted permission, it took him into custody and produced him before the court the next day. The court subsequently remanded Kharat in police custody until April 23.

Due to security reasons, the court proceedings were held through video conferencing on Thursday.



assaulting several women and indulging in large-scale financial fraud by claiming to have divine powers and knowledge of black magic.

In the fifth case, Kharat allegedly sexually exploited a married woman who had approached him for help with her family problems. He also allegedly warned her that her son's life would be in danger if she spoke about the exploitation, according to the police.

The Maharashtra Government has set up a Special Investigation Team to probe cases of sexual assault and financial fraud registered against Kharat.

He is facing at least 12 criminal cases in Nashik

The defence did not object after the police demanded judicial custody for Kharat. Accordingly, the court sent Kharat to judicial custody till May 6, which means he will now be sent to Nashik Road Central Jail, said officials.

The SIT will produce Kharat in court again on Friday in the sixth case, involving alleged sexual harassment of a woman.

Kharat has been at the centre of a political firestorm as he was well-connected, and photographs of him with political leaders and other important members of society have been surfacing in mainstream and social media regularly since his arrest.



Editor's
TAKE

West Bengal votes: Ballot and boundaries

The fiercely contested West Bengal election began on April 23, but the central question is not who will be voted to power, but who will be allowed to vote

In West Bengal, the fiercest contest unfolded on April 23, 2026, when voting took place in 152 of 294 seats across 16 districts in the first phase, as the fate of 1,478 candidates in the fray was locked in EVMs. The day was marked by sporadic violence but largely went as per plan. The second phase of polling is scheduled for next week. The West Bengal contest is less a referendum on governance and more a test of identity, documents, and political mobilisation. There are two key things to observe in this election – who gets to vote, and how many votes and seats the BJP secures, as it has finally emerged as the main challenger to the entrenched TMC, relegating the Left and Congress to sidelines.

Interestingly, the Election Commission of India has become an active player, taking up the SIR in haste despite numerous representations and even a court order stating that minor discrepancies in spelling, etc, must be overlooked. Moreover, this is one of the most heavily secured elections, with the ECI deploying 2,407 companies of Central forces for the first phase. Added to this to make air thick is the “final warning” from Prime Minister Narendra Modi that no TMC goon, syndicate, or corrupt element would be spared. In a state that has seen three consecutive terms of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) under Mamata Banerjee, the natural expectation would have been a verdict on performance – jobs, industry, agrarian distress, and social welfare. Instead, the discourse has veered sharply towards the contentious Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, reshaping both the narrative and the odds.

At the heart of this election lies the fallout of the SIR exercise conducted by the Election Commission of India. A staggering 91 lakh voters – roughly 12 per cent of the electorate – were dropped during the revision. Subsequent scrutiny flagged over 60 lakh names for “logical discrepancies,” and despite judicial intervention, nearly 27 lakh electors remain disenfranchised, with uncertain recourse through tribunals.

On the ground, especially in border and minority-heavy regions, this has led to anger, confusion, and a sense of exclusion. The TMC has capitalised on this, portraying the SIR as a politically motivated move by the Centre and an indifferent Election Commission. Its campaign has focused on welfare schemes while raising concerns over voter suppression. Mamata Banerjee harped upon protecting Bengali identity and called for resisting external interference. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) campaign, highly centralised and resource-intensive, has focused on consolidating Hindu votes, sharpening identity lines, and presenting itself as the agent of “clean governance” and national integration. The BJP's organisational groundwork appears significantly strengthened compared to previous elections. The BJP has made inroads through aggressive campaigning and strategic alliances, particularly in northern and border constituencies. The TMC retains a formidable grassroots presence in rural Bengal. How the voters perceived the situation and the impact of the SIR on the election will be known only after the results are declared on May 4.

Rethinking global tourism rankings

Global rankings are frequently seen as impartial scorecards – subtle yet powerful judges of performance. This is especially evident in tourism, where such indices exert an outsized influence on perception, policy direction, and investment decisions



SUMAN
BILLA

Global rankings carry quiet but formidable influence. They shape how countries are perceived, where capital flows, and which policy choices are prioritised. In tourism, few instruments are as widely followed as the World Economic Forum's Travel & Tourism Development Index (TTDI). Governments track it closely; investors rely on it as a proxy for credibility, and the media amplifies its findings with little interrogation.

Yet, for all its authority, the index raises an important question: does it truly measure comparative performance, or does it reflect structural advantage?

A closer reading of the 2024 rankings suggests a pattern that is difficult to ignore. High-income economies occupy 26 of the top 30 positions, with Europe alone accounting for 19. These are countries that already dominate global tourism, contributing over three-fourths of tourism GDP and nearly 70 per cent of post-pandemic growth. The index, rather than disrupting this concentration, appears to mirror it.

What is presented as benchmarking, therefore, risks becoming a reinforcement of existing hierarchies.

The explanation lies, in part, in the architecture of the index. The TTDI assigns equal weight to 17 pillars, treating a wide range of variables as though they evolve on similar timelines.

In reality, they do not. Indicators such as air connectivity, rail density, hotel capacity, and urban infrastructure are the product of decades or often centuries of sustained investment. Advanced economies naturally perform strongly on these parameters. When such legacy-heavy indicators are given equal importance alongside recent reforms or policy innovation, the outcome becomes predictable. Countries that began with an advantage continue to retain it.

The result is a framework that tends to privilege historical accumulation over recent momentum.

India's position offers a useful lens into this dynamic. Ranked 39th, above the global average and leading among comparable economies, it has nevertheless slipped since 2019, despite significant improvements in aviation capacity, digital infrastructure, and tourism assets.

The signal is subtle but important. Progress is recognised, but it does not always translate



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PERCEPTION AND
PERFORMANCE

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into upward movement.

Overlaying this structural issue is another challenge, which is scale. Nearly fifteen indicators within the TTDI rely on per capita metrics. For a country of India's size, this creates an inherent statistical disadvantage. Even as infrastructure expands rapidly in absolute terms, per capita ratios appear

modest when compared to smaller nations. This effect is further accentuated by the use of standardised population estimates, which may not fully capture the most recent demographic dynamics, leading to scores that reflect arithmetic compression rather than actual capability.

The methodology also draws significantly on perception-based surveys, particularly from business respondents. These perceptions are often anchored in benchmarks set by advanced economies. Countries operating within different cost-to-quality equilibria are therefore assessed against standards that may not fully reflect their context. The result is not necessarily a failure of performance, but a mismatch in expectations.

Even pillars that appear inherently neutral, such as natural and cultural resources, are influenced by factors beyond intrinsic value. Visibility plays a critical role. Digital footprint, branding strength, and global discoverability shape outcomes as much as the richness of the resource itself. Heritage that is less amplified globally risks being undervalued, irrespective of its depth.

Perhaps the most complex dimension is the inclusion of variables that lie outside the immediate domain of tourism policy. Credit ratings, passport mobility, globalisation

indices, and UNESCO listings are shaped by broader geopolitical and economic factors. Yet, they feed directly into tourism rankings, further tilting the balance towards countries with longstanding structural advantages.

Taken together, these elements create a system where progress is visible but not always sufficiently rewarded. Countries like

India are acknowledged for their strengths and trajectory, but moving significantly higher in the rankings often requires factors that take decades to build—such as deep infrastructure, global brand recall, and institutional maturity.

This is not a critique of the index as much as it is a case for its evolution.

If global rankings are to remain relevant in a rapidly changing world, they must increasingly distinguish between structural advantage and policy effort, between scale and efficiency, and between perception and performance. Doing so would make them more reflective of contemporary realities and more useful as tools for policymaking.

For emerging economies, including India, there is also an opportunity to engage constructively in this recalibration by ensuring that global frameworks capture not just where countries stand, but how they are progressing.

Because ultimately, the question is not simply about rank. It is about whether the metrics we rely on are aligned with the outcomes we seek.

If they are, rankings can serve as valuable guides. If not, they risk becoming elegant reflections of the past rather than meaningful indicators of the future.

PIC TALK



Priests perform 'aarti' during the 'Ganga Saptami' festival, at Assi Ghat in Varanasi.

PHOTO: PTI

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Can the UN be revived for the world's sake?



ASHA IYER
KUMAR

2ND OPINION

Even as the Gulf war slowly turns into a war of egos and a load of baloney from everyone involved, one reality stands out - the diminished relevance of the United Nations in the entire drama. The first time I heard about the UN was in school where we had annual examinations that I took not knowing for what reason. It, however, gave me an overview of the organisation which I felt was very impressive even at that young age — a league of nations instituted to prevent future wars. Schools now conduct model UN simulations to help students learn more about its functions and principles, but it makes one wonder, to what end all the understanding if the organisation itself stands powerless and peripheral in the face of mindless violence and aggression around the globe?

The UN Secretary general's latest words on the war as “a rising tide of human suffering, and a deeper global economic shock”, sound like platitudes that do very little to bring any shift in the way the conflict is moving, and inconsistent with its original objective of playing an integral part in avoiding global conflagrations post World War II. With each instance of clash between nations, the UN's original aims seem to get dismantled, one cog at a time.

A quick read-up of the UN's history reveals how despite the bold ambitions, it was often paralysed in its initial years by the prolonged discord between the US and the USSR. In the 1990s, it had some role to play in limiting conflicts from escalating into global wars with its peacekeeping operations and interventions. But then came an era where the UN began to lose its grip on member nations that rose in stature to such an extent that their belligerent voices stood above the peace-loving pleas of the UN. The rise of a multi-polar world and regional powers made sure that it was heard lesser and lesser, and now as we see, its voice has been reduced to a whimper appealing for peace with no one to heed.

The increasing geo-political divisions have reduced the role of the UN from being an enforcer to that of a mediator, and that too with limited impact. Donald

Trump's stance towards the UN has been one of scepticism and open disregard. Given that his initiatives are tilted towards serving American interest and not in maintaining world order, his assessment of the UN as biased and inefficient sounds more like a death sentence on the institution. His withdrawals and reduced

engagement with specialised agencies like the UNHRC, WHO and UNESCO makes one wonder — if the super power itself doesn't stand in tandem with the values on which the UN was built, how then does the rest of the world honour it?

Of what value are UN resolutions when major powers exercise vetoes based on national interest? Wars continue, and nations increasingly rely on bilateral or regional arrangements, reducing the UN to a forum for discussion rather than action. Yet, despite its limitations, the UN remains vital in humanitarian crises. It feeds millions, shelters refugees, vaccinates children, and supports populations affected by conflict and disaster. The prospect of it regaining its role as a deterrent force seems unlikely — a troubling reality. Its decline reflects a deeper failure of global commitment to peace and collective responsibility.

The writer is a Dubai-based author, columnist, independent journalist and children's writing coach

FREEBIE POLITICS UNDERMINES PUBLIC HEALTH AND ECONOMIC STABILITY

The growing competition of freebie politics during elections has become a matter of concern for democracy. Cash assistance schemes and populist promises made in the name of women may provide short-term relief, but they create a heavy burden on state finances in the long run. States such as West Bengal and Tamil Nadu are already facing pressure due to rising debt and increasing interest payments. In such a situation, the introduction of new giveaway schemes risks diverting resources from essential development priorities.

As a result, crucial sectors such as education, healthcare, employment generation, and infrastructure often suffer neglect. Reduced investment in these areas can ultimately weaken public health systems, limit job creation, and slow economic progress. Welfare measures that are not

backed by sustainable fiscal planning may create long-term vulnerabilities rather than genuine empowerment.

True women's empowerment cannot be achieved through cash transfers alone. It requires access to quality education, safe and meaningful employment opportunities, skill development, financial independence, and equal rights.

Political parties must therefore move beyond short-term vote bank considerations and adopt a more balanced approach. Welfare policies should aim to build long-term capacity and resilience among citizens rather than fostering dependency on periodic benefits. Only prudent and forward-looking governance can ensure that social justice is achieved alongside economic stability.

AMRIT LAL MARU | INDORE

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BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Decentralising India's highest court

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has suggested that a Supreme Court bench be set up in South India. He, of course, is a politician. Several legal luminaries and constitutional experts have also expressed similar views in the past regarding decongesting the principal seat of justice. However, whenever people of eminence advocate the setting up of additional Supreme Court benches, strong opposition arises, as the Court itself appears averse to any move seen as undermining its supremacy.

The full court of the Supreme Court had rejected the Law Commission's 2009 report recommending the division of the Court into four appellate benches across the country. It is widely believed that such regional benches could handle routine appeals from High Courts, while the principal bench in Delhi focuses exclusively on constitutional matters.

Improving access to justice for economically weaker citizens and litigants remains the primary reason for advocating such reform. Article 130 of the Constitution permits the Supreme Court to sit outside Delhi if approved. With mounting case backlogs and delays in constitutional matters, decentralisation appears both logical and necessary.

Strengthening security through unity

Apropos “Pahalgam: If we forget, we fail them” (April 23), the first anniversary of the tragic attack should not remain merely symbolic but serve as a stark reminder that every life must be protected. The lessons from the bloodied valley must remain central to policy thinking. Encouragingly, the nation responded with unity rather than polarisation—contrary to what perpetrators might have intended.

Following Operation Sindoor, there has been a noticeable decline in terror incidents, yet complacency must be avoided.

While the operation achieved its objectives, national unity remains the strongest deterrent against terrorism. To sustain this, restoring statehood to Jammu and Kashmir could strengthen local governance and build trust between communities, visitors, and authorities.

There is also a pressing need for stronger coordination between intelligence agencies and local security units. Public awareness regarding emergency response and evacuation protocols must be enhanced. As terror tactics evolve, security preparedness must also adapt to counter smaller, unpredictable threats effectively.

Preserving civility in political discourse

The recent issuance of a show-cause notice by the Election Commission of India to Mallikarjun Kharge for his alleged “terrorist” remark against Narendra Modi has once again spotlighted the quality of political discourse in the country. While spirited criticism is an essential feature of democracy, the language employed by public figures must reflect restraint and maturity.

Such intervention by the Commission underscores its responsibility to ensure that public debate remains within acceptable limits, especially during politically charged periods. When rhetoric becomes excessively harsh or provocative, it diverts attention from substantive issues and deepens divisions among the electorate. Healthy disagreement should inform, not inflame, democratic engagement. At the same time, the importance of institutional neutrality cannot be overstated. The credibility of the Election Commission rests on its ability to act impartially and consistently, irrespective of political affiliations. In conclusion, this episode serves as a reminder that political leadership carries the responsibility to elevate, not diminish, the tone of national conversation.

Registration reform must move beyond procedure to protect ownership

Digitisation and efficiency are welcome. But without statutory safeguards and system integration, land registration risks legitimising flawed transactions



VIVEK KUMAR SINGH

India's attempt to modernise its property registration framework through the Draft Registration Bill, 2025, is both timely and necessary. Replacing the colonial-era Registration Act, 1908, the draft promises a digital, paperless, and citizen-friendly regime. Online workflows, electronic documentation, and time-bound service delivery signal a clear shift towards efficiency and transparency.

Yet, for all its procedural ambition, the draft law sidesteps more fundamental questions: who has the right to transact, what is being transacted, and on what basis. By focusing on how transactions are recorded rather than on who is entitled to transact, the reform risks modernising the process without addressing legitimacy.

At the heart of the problem lies a long-standing principle—that registration is a formal act, not a verification of title. A system that does not distinguish between legitimate and questionable claims treats all transactions alike. While administratively convenient, this “neutrality” imposes heavy downstream costs on citizens and the State.

Registering Officers ensure proper execution and authenticate parties but do not examine ownership. The Draft Bill retains this philosophy. As a result, even defective or disputed claims can pass through a digitised system and acquire the appearance of legality. Technology enhances speed, not the integrity of underlying transactions. Without safeguards, it risks accelerating the registration of flawed or fraudulent transfers.

Even where the draft proposes integration with land records, it stops short of requiring alignment between the seller and the current recorded landholder. A simple system-level validation-matching the transacting party with the latest record-could filter out a significant number of questionable transactions. Its absence is a missed opportunity.

This gap is particularly visible in the continued vulnerability of public lands. Categories such as ceiling surplus land, commons, forest lands, and unsurveyed tracts remain prone to encroachment and fraudulent transfers. Once registered, such transactions acquire a veneer of legality that is difficult to undo.

The issue reflects a deeper structural problem. India's land governance remains fragmented across three silos-registration records transactions, revenue records reflect possession, and courts adjudicate title. While the draft law improves interoperability, it falls short of substantive integration. Digitisation without integration risks reinforcing these compartments rather than bridging them.

For citizens, this translates into costly due diligence, dependence on legal intermediaries, and prolonged litigation. Conflicting claims can coexist across databases, leaving resolution to courts. The system records documents, not claims, and places the burden of verification on buyers.

What is needed is not a shift to full title adjudication at the registration stage but a calibrated move towards basic claim validation. This can be achieved without overburdening the system. A pragmatic middle path lies in introducing a limited, document-based pre-registration filter through statutory design.

Past attempts by States to regulate questionable registrations-often through executive instructions-have faced judicial scrutiny. As seen in Samiullah vs State of Bihar, administrative measures cannot exceed the parent statute. In the absence of legislative backing, pre-registration scrutiny mechanisms remain vulnerable. This is not merely a policy gap but a legislative one.

The Draft Registration Bill presents an opportunity to address this through a carefully crafted statutory intervention-possibly via a dedicated chapter on immovable property transactions, akin to proposed provisions for specific instruments such as wills.

Such a framework could rest on three pillars. To begin with, a self-certification requirement for the seller, mandating disclosure of the legal basis of his right to transact. This could involve citing an official



THE CHALLENGE TODAY IS NOT MERELY TO MAKE REGISTRATION FASTER OR MORE EFFICIENT. IT IS TO ENSURE THAT IT IS CREDIBLE, CONNECTED, AND LEGALLY ROBUST

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record-such as a mutation entry, Record of Rights, municipal holding, or any document notified by the State. The Registering Officer's role would remain procedural-ensuring that the declaration is furnished, not adjudicating its correctness.

Second, the creation of a negative or protected list of lands-such as ceiling surplus land, commons, forest land, ecologically sensitive zones, and unsurveyed tracts-drawn from departmental databases. Registrations involving such categories could be restricted or flagged for higher scrutiny.

Third, providing a statutory mandate for system integration across registration, revenue, municipal, and forest databases. With appropriate technological interfaces, sellers not linked to any recognised database could be automatically filtered out, reducing the risk of fraudulent transactions.

Together, these measures would introduce light-touch yet effective pre-registration filters. They would not convert registration into title adjudication, nor impose unreasonable burdens on officials. Instead, they would create a basic layer of traceability, accountability, and deterrence.

Such safeguards would strengthen the evidentiary value of registered documents, create a clearer linkage between the seller and the property, and provide courts with a more reliable trail of claims. The requirement of disclosure-backed by penalties for false declarations-would also deter frivolous or malicious transactions.

Importantly, this approach respects federal diversity. Land record systems vary widely across States in structure and reliability. The law should therefore remain flexible in nature, allowing States to notify acceptable records and adapt mechanisms to local conditions.

While no system can eliminate disputes entirely, such reforms would significantly reduce avoidable ones. More crucially, they would enhance trust in the registration system-transforming it from a passive recorder of documents into an active enabler of legal certainty.

The challenge today is not merely to make registration faster or more efficient. It is to ensure that it is credible, connected, and legally robust. With the right statutory design, the new Registration Act can rise to that challenge.

Congress-led opposition crosses the rubicon



KARUNA GOPAL VARTAKAVI

The opposition parties led by Congress did cross the Rubicon this time. This point of no return, leading to a dark alley, will cause irreversible damage to southern states and to the women of India. By stalling the 131st Amendment to the Constitution, these opposition parties were thumping their chests, arrogating victory to themselves, but anyone with a modicum of knowledge will call it a self-goal-a serious self-inflicted injury that the opposition has caused itself.

Priyanka Gandhi said that it was a victory for democracy. It was the NDA's conspiracy to stay at the Centre for longer. But now, thanks to their stubborn, incurable hatred for anything called reform, the women of the country will not get the 33 per cent reservation in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies. The Congress and its allies have not only cut but ensured that the wound will not heal any time soon.

At the heart of the controversy lies the structure of the Bill itself. It was not a stand-alone women's reservation measure, but part of a larger package linked to delimitation. The proposed amendment sought to increase the strength of the Lok Sabha from 543 to a maximum of 815 seats. The 33 per cent reservation for women was tied to this expanded House, to be implemented after a fresh delimitation exercise based on updated population data. Parties such as the Congress, DMK, and Trinamool Congress argued that delimitation based on population would disproportionately affect southern states, which have seen slower population growth compared to the Hindi heartland.

Did they even know that the NDA's proposal was a sincere effort to preserve the federal balance, protect the voice of southern, north-eastern, and smaller states, and ensure 33 per cent representation for women? And that it recognised that states which have performed well on key development indicators should not be penalised in the democratic structure? The Government proposed a 50 per cent increase model. Total seats to increase from 543 to 815. Every state's seats would grow by 50 per cent pro rata. The predicted rise of seats for Karnataka is from 28 to 42, Andhra Pradesh from 25 to 38, Telangana from 17 to 26, Tamil Nadu from 39 to 59, and Kerala from 20 to 30. Thanks to Rahul Gandhi and his supporters, without the “50 per cent pro rata” guarantee, we move to a strict population model after the 2026 Census results come. See its implications. Based on current data, the South is projected to lose actual seats-Tamil Nadu -10; Kerala -7; Andhra -5. The North/Central belt will see a massive power surge because their population has exploded since 1971. Uttar Pradesh +12; Bihar +10; Rajasthan +7; and Madhya Pradesh +5 seats.

The irony is that southern leaders like M.K. Stalin and Rahul Gandhi led the charge against the Bill. But by doing so, they have lost the only legal prop that was keeping southern seat counts high. Because the Delimitation Bill was linked to the Women's Reservation Bill, the 33 per cent quota for women is now likely to be pushed from 2029 to 2034 or later. Will the women of India, who have been waiting patiently for decades, forgive the opposition?

So, what's next? The 2026 Census will proceed and, by law (Article 82), delimitation must follow. Without a new political consensus, the North will gain enough seats to potentially decide the Union Government without needing a single seat from the South.

Was the opposition flying blind?

The Women's Reservation Bill, which was passed in 2023, is linked to Article 334A. Article 334A states that the reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies, including Delhi, will come into effect only after a fresh Census is published and a fresh delimitation exercise is completed. Why? Because new constituencies have to be redrawn and allocated so that seats reserved for women can be distributed across states and regions. The Women's Reservation Bill, 2023, repeatedly states that the reservation cannot be applied in the current Lok Sabha of 543 seats until after delimitation redraws constituencies and allocates reserved seats for women across states.

Historical roots and role of Congress

The actual problem started with the 1976 constitutional amendment carried out by Indira Gandhi, the then Prime Minister, who announced the Emergency. This amendment was carried out without any discussion, as she jailed all the opposition leaders. Ms Gandhi, who was focused on population control, connected population with delimitation. In other words, she wanted population control through delimitation. The Constitution mandates that delimitation and the Census take place every 10 years. This principle was violated by Indira Gandhi when she froze the process for 25 long years.

That is why the Constitution's framework emphasises that delimitation has to take place every 10 years based on a decennial Census. It is indeed a fact that delimitation helped Karnataka and Kerala increase their parliamentary seats by two members-Karnataka from 26 to 28, and Kerala from 18 to 20. This was in 1961.

Today, the country is misled by the Opposition into believing that southern states are being discriminated against. Then whose idea was population control?

But regional parties like TMC, DMK, SP, and BRS have an incentive to instigate this type of regional feeling to gain power. So they did just that.

According to the BJP, this 131st Constitutional Amendment is a battle of “neeyat” (intent). That is why PM Modi said, “We don't want credit. I give you a blank cheque for claiming credit on the passage of the women's quota Bill. If you want me to use the word ‘guarantee’, I will use the word ‘guarantee’. If you want me to make a promise, I will use the word ‘promise’. Because if the intention is clear, there is no need to play games with words.” It is now clear that the BJP backed a Bill that would eventually ensure 33 per cent reservation for women in legislatures, while opposition parties blocked it.

It is not an exaggeration to say that the opposition parties achieved a self-goal, as they stand to lose not only Lok Sabha seats but also the goodwill of the women of India.

This narrative war will continue until such time as the voters of India understand the constitutional framework, the nuances of governance, and the past performance of Congress completely.



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 The Pioneer

From right to work to right to rest: Rethinking digital-age labour norms



VISHWARUPA BHATTACHARYA

In an age where work travels home in our pockets, the boundary between professional obligation and personal life has become increasingly fragile. Smartphones, instant messaging platforms, and remote-working technologies have not only transformed how we work, but they have also transformed when we work. The result is a culture of permanent availability, where logging off is often perceived not as rest, but as neglect. Against this backdrop, the idea of a “Right to Disconnect” has emerged as a critical intervention in contemporary labour discourse.

During the last Winter Session of Parliament, a Private Member's Bill, introduced by Smt Supriya Sule in the Lok Sabha, drew attention for addressing this lived reality. The Bill, titled “The Right to Disconnect Bill, 2025”, seeks to grant employees a legal right to disengage from work-related digital communications beyond designated working hours. At its core, it aims to restore a healthier work-life balance in a hyper-connected world, where flexibility has quietly transformed into round-the-clock work expectations.

Health toll of being ‘Always Online’

Several studies show that excessive digital connectivity has serious physical and mental health consequences. Prolonged screen exposure leads to eye strain, musculoskeletal pain, and disrupted sleep. Constant online engagement is also linked to anxiety, depression, cardiovascular disease, obesity, and burnout. Reduced attention spans, social withdrawal, and emotional fatigue are now widely recognised outcomes of perpetual notifications and digital overload.

These findings often lead to a familiar prescription: reduce social media usage. While this advice is sound, it is also incomplete. Digital connectivity today is not limited to voluntary leisure activity. A significant portion of screen time is driven by professional requirements-late-night emails, assignments, and messages on weekends, calls, and the expectation of an instant response.

Rising burnout and disturbing trends in India

The pressures of a 24x7 work culture are no longer limited to stress or burnout-they now carry serious human costs. In recent years, India has witnessed cases of employees, particularly in high-pressure sectors like IT, dying by suicide after prolonged overwork, unrealistic targets,



and constant digital surveillance. These incidents are a stark reminder of how constant connectivity can push individuals beyond their emotional and physical limits.

Pandemic-era lessons and the erosion of boundaries

The COVID-19 pandemic, which accelerated the shift to hybrid and remote work models, blurred boundaries between work and personal life. Employees routinely responded to emails, calls, and messages late into the night. What began as an exceptional response to an unprecedented crisis, however, gradually became a norm. This Bill seeks to reverse that erosion by clearly defining when a worker is not obligated to engage in work-related communication.

From the right to work to the right to unwork

This is where the Right to Disconnect intersects with the broader Right to Health. Health is not merely the absence of illness; it includes mental well-being, adequate rest, family life, and the ability to recover from work. If employees remain digitally tethered to their workplace beyond official hours, the right to health becomes hollow. The right to disconnect, therefore, is not a competing claim, but an extension of health protection in the digital age.

At a deeper level, the debate reflects a shift from the “right to work” to the emerging idea of a “right to unwork.” While the right to work ensures livelihood and dignity, the right to unwork recognises that rest and disengagement are not indulgences but essential conditions for sustainable productivity. In a digital economy, unwork is not idleness; it is recovery.

Global practices and the challenges ahead

Globally, variations of the right to disconnect already exist in France, Belgium, Italy, Spain, Ireland, Australia, and parts of Canada. Evidence from some of these countries shows that, while such measures do not entirely eliminate after-hours work-related communication, they have a meaningful positive impact on work-life balance, health, and job satisfaction.

Despite the positive impact, the right to disconnect is still not widely adopted because constant availability has become normalised in modern work culture, where quick responses are often seen as a sign of commitment. For many employees, particularly in white-collar, IT, consulting, media, and gig-economy sectors, disconnecting from work is not a matter of choice but of risk. The practical application of this right also becomes complicated in a globalised economy, where companies operate across time zones and rely on round-the-clock responsiveness, making strict restrictions on after-hours communication hard to sustain. Further, labour laws remain out of sync with the changing rhythms and expectations of online work. The right to disconnect cannot completely stop after-office work, but with such legislation in place, it can at least give employees the legal right to switch off. Without this protection, many workers feel afraid to log off because they worry they will be seen as less dedicated.

India discussing this issue marks an important moment in acknowledging the pressures of modern work culture. For a nation with a rapidly expanding digital workforce, this proposal reflects a forward-looking approach to labour welfare.

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It is the same old story that has repeated ad-nauseum for the past three weeks. Iran makes a claim, the US counters it, and vice versa. In other cases, if Iran shoots down some locations, or captures a few ships, and helps its vessels to escape, the US retorts with similar or larger bombings and captures, and vice versa. Hence, it is not surprising that when Iran claimed to have captured two vessels that were illegally, according to its terms, trying to escape the Strait of Hormuz, the US stated that it had taken control of Iranian vessels doing the same. In the midst of these events, was news that several Iranian tankers went through the American blockade around Kharg Island, where 90 per cent of Iran's oil is stored. In these columns we have discussed the probability, and possibility, of the efficacy of the US blockade, given Iran's past experiences in smuggling oil across the high seas. We have discussed the ramifications on Iran if Kharg Island remains isolated.

But as these news items filter in and out of the newspaper headlines, TV channels' breaking news, and digital exclusives, oil analysts and experts are converging on a consensus about global prices. News reports indicate that Standard Chartered feels that a price of \$95 a barrel "appears to represent an uneasy equilibrium between hopes of de-escalation, and structural tightness in physical balances that is increasing as time passes." In essence, what this implies is that since the oil prices are now wavering and fluctuating due to news that is either emanating from the US side, which depresses the price, or Iranian one, which pushes it up, \$95 has emerged as the benchmark. Oil will rise to over \$100, or even \$110-120, if the conflict continues, and the US blockade fails compared to the Iranian one. But then it will settle down to \$95 or so, and not really fall below it, on the appearance of pro-peace, and pro-ceasefire headlines. In the past few days, the prices for crude deliveries in June 2026 have settled around this price.

According to a media report, "StanChart notes that near-term oil price movements are now largely headline-driven, constantly taking direction from escalation and de-escalation in the US-Iran conflict amid tightening in physical oil markets. Constrained transit through the Strait of Hormuz has forced Gulf producers to shut-in production, with countries in the region cutting output by between 25 per cent and 80 per cent while spare capacity tightness, and reliance on certain transit routes has been highlighted. The oil experts expect this theme to continue even when OPEC launches its maximum sustainable capacity metric." The metric was decided last year, and the assessment process to decide production baselines for 2027 were scheduled in the first half of 2026. Although the discussions are derailed, the participants can quickly come to the table to decide production for 2027. The new metric aims to do away with the political language in the earlier quotas for the member-producer nations. The new language states that the sustainable capacity will be decided by the "average maximum number of barrels a day of crude oil that can be produced within 90 days, and can be sustained continuously for one full year, including all planned maintenance activities." The objectives are to reward members who invest in upstream projects, improve transparency, and combat overproduction.

If one moves away from the \$95 benchmark, and given this new metric that will be in operation after the war, most experts feel that the days of expensive crude will prolong for at least a year or two, and definitely for more than six months. The days of cheap crude are not going to return immediately. Indeed, StanChart predicts that prices will be \$10-20 higher than the pre-conflict days and, hence, hover around the \$90 mark. This will happen "even after the acute stage of the conflict ends, supported by purchasing for strategic reserves (which are being emptied as we write), a focus on resource nationalism, and hoarding, as well as the logistical lags caused by the disruption." Unexpectedly, the good news stems from gas prices. Despite the loss of most of the gas supplies from the Middle East, especially after the vicious attacks on Qatar gas infrastructure by Iran, prices have dropped by more than 60 per cent. European prices are down by a fourth. According to a media report, the "expected volumes to be delivered to the market outweigh current and expected reductions over the next few years, helping to contain the market short-fall, and associated price reaction."

But as we have seen in the recent past, both after the 2022 Russia-Ukraine war, and now in the past three weeks after the Iran war, the oil and gas prices, both spot and future, move like a roller-coaster ride. They have dropped and soared by 10-20 per cent within a day or two, for no demand-supply reasons, except the changing headlines, which unfortunately change within minutes, hours, and days. Thus, what seems plausible now, like higher oil prices, and lower gas prices, may change in the future, with greater probabilities. One is not sure how the warring nations, and non-warring energy producers and consumers are likely to act, and react over the next several months.

The Pioneer

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BUSINESS

10

OUR TAKE

Grand Spectacular Theft via GST

Fraudsters create false invoices to establish trading and sales trails

It is possibly the largest GST scam. A set of scamsters collected refunds worth more than ₹1,800 crore from the GST authorities across multiple jurisdictions. What is crucial is that they gamed the entire supply chain, from product purchases, sales through various firms, e-way transport bills, to final shipments via exports. Similar past cases, yet again worth ₹1,000-2,000 crore, prove that the fraudsters manage to capture the GST system, as it exists. Such examples highlight "systemic abuse of the ITC (input tax credit) mechanism through fake billings, and fictitious exports" or sales. Hence, the expanse of the scams is deeper, and almost-impossible to detect.

Let us begin with the abuse of the policy. Since GST is paid at several levels during the movement of the goods, there is a mechanism to claim refunds of the taxes paid on the inputs, or at the earlier stages. In some cases, this is not allowed, especially after GST 2.0 since the tax rate is either zero, or minimal (five per cent). Exports definitely, invariably, and implicitly involve such refunds. Dubbed as ITC, the system was abused from the beginning, and nudged the policy-makers to regularly plug loopholes, and tax agencies to systematically investigate them.

Now comes the selection of the product, which needs to be put into play. Most criminals choose items that attract low taxes. Although the refunds are smaller, possibly a few hundred crores of rupees, detection is difficult since no one cares about low-ticket products. In the ₹1,800-crore scam, the mastermind, who allegedly fled to Dubai, picked out tobacco-based products, which attract the highest GST. These included tobacco, smoking mixtures, and other ingredients that are part of the chewing culture. The amount of the ITC-based refunds was huge in value and percentage.

Being smart, this criminal gang pursued two strategies. First, it did not establish either genuine or fake manufacturing or production facilities, which are easy to detect. Instead, in one

of the modus operandi, the procurement of the goods was merely on paper, or fake. In effect, there were no goods, and these fake products moved through an elaborate paper trail. In the other surreptitious route, the goods were purchased locally at nominal, and extremely cheap prices, mostly without invoices, whose prices were inflated, and which were shown as high-value tobacco-based products. These included "low-value tobacco, inferior smoking mixtures," and other ingredients (kimam and jarda). Hence, it followed a two-fold illegal process, both to claim ITC refunds.

However, there were dozens of intermediary firms, which sold the 'paper' goods, and genuine but cheap and waste materials shown as high-priced ones from one entity to another in a hierarchical chain. Borrowed KYC documents were used to register the firms legally. But they were shelf companies that were "non-functional," lacked "infrastructure and manpower," and did not conduct "genuine business activity at the declared premises (registered offices)." Thus, these firms too operated merely on paper, and their names were used to create invoices to sell the 'paper' or low-value but real goods to each other.

The owners and directors of these 'dummy' firms, i.e., legally existing but non-operational, were real, but 'benami' in many senses. Such persons merely lent their names to the criminal outfit, which used the names to create credibility and genuineness. The owners and directors were paid fixed monthly payments, only in cash. They were mere paper stamps, or benami signatories. "All the operational activities, including GST registrations, banking operations, filing of returns, and submission of the refund claims," apart from the generation of the invoices was handled by the gang, and its main, and now escaped, mastermind.

In some cases, the fake purchase invoices, largely for the non-existent 'paper' products, were

circulated through the dummy and benami intermediaries, which established a "layered chain of transactions." The goods passed from one entity to another, and resulted in an "artificial trail of trading activity." This GST and trading chain enabled the gang to introduce the illegal, and ineligible, GST and, hence, ITC, into the system. Since GST was paid at several levels, at least on paper, a huge value of ITC could be claimed. In other cases, where genuine but low-value goods existed, these were sold in the same manner as high-value goods, which attracted huge GST, to help claim higher ITC.

Of course, there was another part of the GST system that needed to be cracked, and something which is seriously tracked by the tax agencies. Indeed, this is one of the most prominent ways to pinpoint abuses, misuses, evasions, and tax avoidances. This is the presence of e-way bills for transport and logistics. Investigations revealed that such bills were generated through the use of "doubtful or repeated vehicle numbers, and fabricated transport documents." They supported the movement of goods indicated by the false purchase invoices. Now, the technical part of the system was almost complete.

What was left was a financial trail, the smell of the money passing through the various intermediary entities. Despite the high-value transactions that were shown on the invoices for tobacco-based products, there were surprisingly minimal payments in the respective bank accounts, or merely circular movement of the funds among these entities. The firms did not show payments to suppliers, or expenditure on logistics, offices, and administration. This was possibly the weak link in the scam chain. If the GST trail was robust, no one would check the finances. At least, this is possibly what the criminal mastermind thought.

Finally, there were entities that were projected or registered as exporters, which mostly operated from the Kandla Special Economic Zone in Gujarat, renowned as Asia's first and once India's largest export processing zone. After the layered trading trail, the goods reached the firms, which sold the existing low-value goods, or non-existent ones, to overseas buyers at highly-exaggerated prices. In both cases, the export documents were illegal. The first mis-declared the products as high-value tobacco products, and the second generated documents for the fake products. Thus, the gang was able to show high export turnovers in high-value products.

Multiple firms within this scam shared "common contact numbers, Internet IP addresses, accounting personnel," physical addresses, and other elements. This proved the mastermind, or the gang operated through centralised controls. One of the gang members was booked by Sebi in March 2026 for inflating the valuation of a listed firm through bogus billings, fake turnovers, and GST fraud. The escapee mastermind was accused of other frauds, which include getting credit facilities via forged documents. For example, he ripped off at least ₹11 crore as credit from Yes Bank by showing inflated export turnover.

Corruption-Laced Reforms

Actor cops off with smugglers

The curious gold-plated case of a celebrity, policeman and criminals

known location for gold and narcotics smuggling, the Indian investigators smelt a huge rat. They were convinced that this was a part of the larger, planned, and methodical operation, which included more than the duo, which conveniently included a celebrity who is unlikely to be stopped at airports, and jeweller who can easily peddle the gold in the Indian market, and keep it off the books.

By now, Ranya's stepfather was forced to step in. He was a DGP, whose family links were highlighted by the media and political opposition. The cop was immediately suspended, and a special team investigated his role in the gold smuggling. The suspension was later revoked, but the stepfather found himself embroiled in another scandal. This time he was seen in a sleaze video in his police uniform. This led to another suspension which, according to media reports,

continues. There were too many clear and blurred criminal-cop-celebrity links.

This explains why officials claim that the case is not shut with Ranya and Jain's release. The one-year detention finished, and investigating agencies did not contest the releases. But the legal proceedings continue. Multiple agencies are involved to explore and establish the alleged smuggling routes, and whether they involve other actors and locations, including a well-oiled gang. Their eyes are on the money trail to determine the recipients of the Hawala money in Dubai, and where it went from there. Officials feel that more information can come out in the future, which may implicate Indians and foreigners.

According to a media report, "With her COFEPOSA term completed, Ranya Rao leaves prison but remains at the centre of

the gold smuggling case, facing a large financial penalty, and continuing scrutiny from several agencies. The investigations, court hearings, and government review of DGP... role ensure the matter stays active within legal and administrative systems." However, knowing how the agencies operate, this may be a way for them to look for legitimate exit options. They possibly have not found anything much in the past 12 months, but hope that they will dig up more dirt, or rather gold, in the future.

Over the years, the air route has emerged as one of the preferred and modern ways to smuggle gold, with willing human mules and even celebrities readily available to transport it. In the pre-reform days, airline crews, and other prominent members were involved in the smuggling. However, what is surprising is the revival of the sea and land routes for smuggling not just gold, but other contraband like narcotics. Recently, the Indian Coast Guard has upped its ante, and captured several ships laden with large amounts of drugs worth thousands of dollars in the illegal retail markets.

Last year, there was news about smuggling of 1,000 kgs of gold worth ₹800 crore across the India-Tibet-China border, along the Line of Actual Control. Porters and mules were used to transport the yellow metal across the land routes through the mountains and passes in Tibet and Ladakh. Individuals in the Capital received the gold from the Indian side, and sold it to gold dealers and traders. The payments were made in untraceable cryptos to the Chinese suppliers. For decades, both India and China have emerged as the largest gold consumers.

A few years ago, a celebrity-civil servant kind of a case erupted in Kerala, not unlike Ranya Rao's one in Bengaluru. In the former case, gold was smuggled through diplomatic bags that were meant to be delivered at the office of a foreign consulate. One of the alleged accused was a consulate employee, who had earlier worked for a state-level public sector. At the latter job, she was linked to the principal secretary to the chief minister, who was later suspended and investigated. Hence, the links between fame, policing, and crime are quite strong.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Geopolitical shocks and strains



LEKHA CHAKRABORTY

Global uncertainty has hardened from a periodic disturbance into a defining macroeconomic condition. For India, this is no longer an external backdrop but a set of forces shaping domestic monetary policy, fiscal arithmetic and interGovernmental relations. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Ministry of Finance are navigating a world where energy volatility, geopolitical tensions, capital flow reversals and supply disruptions interact in persistent and complex ways. These pressures are increasingly transmitted through India's federal architecture, exposing state Governments to global shocks without commensurate policy flexibility.

The RBI's decision to hold the policy repo rate at 5.25 per cent reflects a calibrated pause rather than inertia. Inflation, after an unusually benign phase in 2025, is normalising towards the 4.5-4.7 per cent range. Yet the risks are clearly tilted upward. Brent crude crossing \$100 per barrel has reintroduced imported inflation pressures, particularly through fuel, fertilisers and transport costs. Inflationary expectations, especially led from food and energy components, remain sensitive to such shocks. The central bank's dilemma is sharpened: easing too early risks unanchoring expectations, while further tightening could compress a recovery that is already losing momentum.

Complicating this domestic balance is the stance of the US Federal Reserve.

Policy signals from the Fed chair have reinforced a higher-for-longer interest rate environment, strengthening the dollar and tightening global liquidity. For India, this translates into intermittent capital outflows and exchange rate pressures. Episodes of capital flight-particularly from debt markets-have intensified in response to shifting expectations about US interest rates. The rupee, though relatively resilient, has faced depreciation pressures, reflecting both global dollar strength and a widening trade deficit driven by higher energy imports.

Currency depreciation feeds directly into inflation by raising the cost of imports, especially oil. It also complicates monetary transmission. The RBI must manage not only domestic price stability but also external stability, often requiring liquidity adjustments that may not align with domestic growth conditions. This dual concern makes policy calibration more complex in a volatile global environment.

Growth, while still robust by global standards, is moderating. After expanding at around 7.5 per cent in FY26, GDP growth is expected to ease towards the 6.8-7.2 per cent range. External demand is weakening, financial conditions are tightening and domestic consumption remains vulnerable to inflation shocks. Bond markets reflect this uncertainty.

The term structure of interest rates has shown intermittent steepening, with long-term yields embedding inflation expectations, fiscal borrowing pressures and global risk premia. Capital flow volatility has added to liquidity management challenges, reinforcing the RBI's cautious stance.

On the fiscal side, the Union Government's consolidation path-targeting a deficit of 4.3 per cent of GDP-



remains credible but increasingly contingent on favourable assumptions. Higher oil prices widen the current account deficit and increase subsidy burdens, while slower global growth risks dampening tax buoyancy. At the same time, expenditure commitments on infrastructure, welfare and defence remain substantial. Public debt, elevated since the pandemic, constrains fiscal flexibility. War-related uncertainties further complicate fiscal arithmetic, both directly through higher defence spending and indirectly through commodity price volatility.

The deeper and less examined challenge lies in India's fiscal federal structure. State Governments account for a substantial share of public spending, particularly in health, education and infrastructure, yet their fiscal capacity is constrained by limited revenue autonomy and dependence on transfers from

the Centre. In an environment of heightened uncertainty, this dependence becomes a source of instability. InterGovernmental transfers-especially those linked to shared taxes-are inherently volatile, fluctuating with economic cycles and policy decisions. Delays, shortfalls or changes in allocation formulas amplify fiscal uncertainty at the State level.

The result is a fiscal space crunch for states. They must meet committed expenditures-salaries, pensions, interest payments and welfare programmes-even as revenues fluctuate. Borrowing limits imposed by fiscal responsibility frameworks restrict their ability to respond countercyclically. This often leads to compression of capital expenditure, undermining long-term growth prospects. In effect, macroeconomic stabilisation is centralised, while fiscal stress is decentralised.

States too equally face the macroeconomic uncertainties now. Global shocks amplify these federal tensions. Rising energy prices increase subsidy burdens across both Union and state budgets. If the Centre absorbs a larger share, transfers to states may be constrained; if states bear more of the burden, their fiscal stress deepens. Either way, public investment risks being crowded out. The interaction between global volatility and domestic fiscal arrangements thus creates a feedback loop that complicates policy effectiveness.

Supply chain disruptions add another layer of complexity. Maritime choke-points such as the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea have become increasingly fragile, forcing rerouting of shipments via longer routes like the Cape of Good Hope. These disruptions raise freight costs, extend delivery times and increase uncertainty for trade. For India, this affects export competitiveness, port efficiency and logistics costs. Ports face congestion and scheduling disruptions, while industries dependent on imported inputs encounter delays and cost escalations.

Less visible but equally critical is the vulnerability of digital infrastructure. Submarine cables running along these maritime routes carry a significant share of global internet traffic. Disruptions in these corridors can affect financial transactions, services exports and digital platforms. In an economy where digital services are a major growth driver, such risks have systemic implications.

For firms, particularly small and medium enterprises, these uncertainties translate into tighter financial conditions. Credit channels become more risk-averse, with higher risk premia raising effective borrowing costs even without

changes in policy rates. Investment decisions are deferred, especially in sectors exposed to global trade and supply chains. The result is a cascading effect: supply disruptions raise costs, reduced profitability weakens credit-worthiness, and tighter credit further dampens economic activity.

What distinguishes the current phase is its multiplicity and persistence. Unlike the pandemic, which was a singular global shock, today's uncertainty is layered-energy volatility, capital flow reversals, currency pressures, supply chain disruptions and federal fiscal constraints interacting simultaneously. These are not transient disturbances but structural features of the global economy.

For policymakers, this requires a shift from reactive crisis management to proactive resilience building. The RBI must preserve credibility in its inflation-targeting framework while managing exchange rate stability and financial conditions. The Ministry of Finance must pursue fiscal consolidation without undermining growth, prioritising resilience alongside investment. Equally important is the need to strengthen fiscal federalism-ensuring predictability in tax transfers, flexibility in borrowing and greater coordination between the Centre and states.

India's macroeconomic fundamentals remain relatively strong, but resilience in this environment will depend less on headline indicators and more on institutional adaptability — both RBI and Ministry of Finance.

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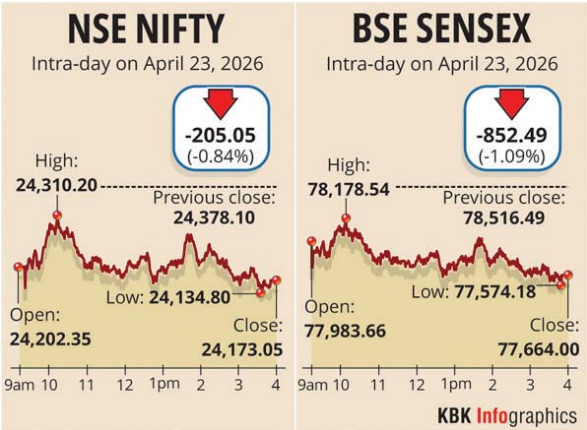
Markets extend losses as crude hits \$100

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Stock markets fell for the second consecutive day on Thursday, with the benchmark Sensex tumbling 852.49 points, as crude oil prices once again breached the \$100 per barrel mark amid stalled US-Iran negotiations. Sustained foreign fund outflows, along with a weak trend in Asian and European equities, also unnerved investors.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 852.49 points, or 1.09 per cent, to settle at 77,664. During the day, it slumped 942.31 points, or 1.20 per cent, to 77,574.18.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 205.05 points, or 0.84 per cent, to end at 24,173.05. From the Sensex pack, Trent, Bajaj Finserv, Tech Mahindra, Mahindra & Mahindra, Infosys and HDFC Bank were among the major



laggards. In contrast, Adani Ports, Larsen & Toubro, Sun Pharma, Bharti Airtel and Bharat Electronics were the winners.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 1.89 per cent higher at \$103.8 per barrel.

"Indian markets extended their losing streak, with the Nifty witnessing back-to-

back bearish sessions and correcting over 400 points across the last two trading days.

The price action reflects a clear shift in market tone — from resilience to risk aversion — as global uncertainties intensify and domestic triggers fail to provide immediate support," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and

founder, Livelong Wealth, said. The primary driver of today's decline remains the sharp escalation in geopolitical tensions in West Asia, he noted.

"Concerns surrounding disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz have significantly dented investor confidence, introducing a fresh layer of uncertainty into global markets.

This has directly translated into a spike in crude oil prices. For an import-dependent economy like India, this creates a dual pressure, rising inflation expectations and stress on corporate margins," Hariprasad said. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹2,078.36 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi ended higher, while Japan's Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's

SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index settled lower.

Markets in Europe were quoting lower in mid-session deals.

"Domestic equities witnessed a broad-based decline, as elevated crude prices above \$100 per barrel, amid the impasse in US-Iran negotiations, continued to weigh on sentiment.

The risk-off mood was further intensified by weak global cues, persistent FII outflows, and a depreciating rupee alongside higher US Treasury yields," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said. US markets ended higher in overnight trade on Wednesday.

On Wednesday, the Sensex tanked 756.84 points, or 0.95 per cent, to settle at 78,516.49. The Nifty dropped 198.50 points, or 0.81 per cent, to end at 24,378.10.

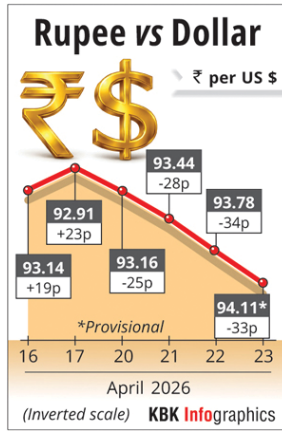
Rupee plummets past 94/USD level; settles 33 paise lower

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee extended its losing streak for the fourth consecutive session, settling 33 paise lower at 94.11 (provisional) on Thursday and breached the 94-level for the second time in a month amid soaring crude oil prices as West Asia peace talks moved to an uncertain trajectory.

Massive selling of domestic equities and incessant withdrawal of foreign funds amid rising worldwide demand for the American currency further weighed on the domestic unit, which has lost over 1 per cent in a week, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.03 and hit an intra-day low of 94.17 against the greenback. It also touched the day's high of



93.98 before ending at 94.11 (provisional) against the US dollar, logging a loss of 33 paise from the previous closing level.

The rupee declined 34 paise to settle at 93.78 against the US dollar on Wednesday, the third straight day of fall. In the past four sessions, the

domestic unit has lost 120 paise, or nearly 1.3 per cent, since the closing level of 92.91 recorded on April 17.

Facing geopolitical headwinds triggered by the war in West Asia that began on February 28, the domestic currency breached the crucial 94-a-dollar level for the first time on March 23 and reached its lowest-ever intra-day level of 95.22 on March 30.

However, the rupee had recovered since then, following a slew of measures from the Reserve Bank of India.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was 0.12 per cent higher at 98.53. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading 1.88 per cent higher at \$103.83 per barrel in futures trade.

West Asia crisis: Rice exports dip 7.5 per cent in 2025-26

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The country's rice exports dipped 7.5 per cent to \$11.53 billion in 2025-26 due to a contraction in shipments to major destinations including the middle east countries, according to the commerce ministry data.

The exports in March declined 15.36 per cent to \$997.53 million. Shipments to middle east region nations, including Iran, UAE, Saudi Arabia and Oman have been impacted due to the war between US-Israel and Iran.

Iran is India's top basmati rice export destination, but



the shipments are witnessing growing stress on order flows, payment cycles, and ship schedules due to the prevailing instability.

As per reports, importers have conveyed their inability to honour existing commitments and remit payments to India, creating uncertainty for exporters. In 2024-25, India exported

20.1 million tonnes of rice valued at \$12.5 billion, reaching more than 172 countries.

India is one of the world's largest producers and exporters of rice.

It produced around 150 million tonnes of rice in 2024-25 from nearly 47 million hectares, accounting for about 28 per cent of global output.

Average yields have improved from 2.72 tonnes per hectare in 2014-15 to about 3.2 tonnes per hectare in 2024-25, driven by improved seed varieties, better agronomic practices, and expanded irrigation coverage.

India's billionaire population may rise 51% to 313 by 2031: Knight Frank

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India is projected to have 25,217 ultra-high net worth individuals and 313 billionaires by 2031, spurred by wealth creation across technology, industrials and capital markets, according to Knight Frank.

Ultra-high Net Worth Individuals (UHNWIs) are defined as those having a net worth of \$30 million and above.

At present, there are 19,877 UHNWIs and 207 billionaires in India.

On Thursday, real estate consultant Knight Frank released its 20th edition of The Wealth Report 2026, stating that there has been "dramatic acceleration" in global wealth creation despite substantial geopolitical uncertainty, concerns over rising interest rates and uneven economic performance.

"India's UHNWI population is forecast to rise from 19,877 today to 25,217 by 2031, under-



scoring its growing role in the global wealth landscape. This reflects extraordinary wealth creation across technology, industrials and capital markets," the consultant said.

Mumbai accounts for 35.4 per cent of the UHNWI population in India.

India now has the sixth-largest UHNWI population in the world.

Globally, the UHNWI population has increased to 713,626 from 551,435 in 2021.

New online gaming rules bring clarity, structure to India's esports ecosystem: Industry

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The freshly-minted online gaming rules unequivocally recognise registered esports as a legitimate sporting discipline, the industry said on Thursday, adding that the overall framework will prevent proxy real-money platforms from masquerading as esports.

Some, however, drew attention to key gaps such as lack of clarity on financial frameworks faced by esports teams and players, and flagged ongoing challenges in how banks differentiate between sports earnings and real money gaming. The comments come in

the backdrop of Centre on Wednesday notifying long-awaited rules to operationalise the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, paving the way for the sector's digital-first regulator, 'online gaming authority', and setting out a "regulation-light" framework that would not require mandatory registration or prior determination/classification for most online social games.

The rules come into effect from May 1, 2026. Akshat Rathee, Co-founder and Managing Director of NODWIN Gaming said the rules bring much-needed clarity and structure to India's esports ecosystem. He termed the provision



for formal registration of titles as esports by publishers "a particularly welcome move" saying it eliminates the risk of misrepresentation and prevents proxy real-money platforms from self-declaring themselves as esports.

The introduction of a 90-day determination process strikes a balance between regulatory scrutiny and certainty.

"For players, teams, tournament operators, broadcasters, sponsors, and other ecosystem participants, this

creates a clear signal: once registered, an esports is unequivocally recognized as a legitimate sporting discipline," Rathee said.

Animesh Agarwal, Co-founder and CEO, S8UL said the norms bring much-needed structure to the ecosystem, clearly separating esports from online money gaming and helping address "long-standing confusion" around the space.

"For organisations like S8UL, this direction allows us to take a more long-term view - investing in talent, scaling teams, and building globally competitive structures with greater confidence," Agarwal said. That said, important gaps

that need to be addressed, he pointed out. "Esports teams and players continue to face a lack of clarity on financial frameworks, with ongoing challenges in how banks differentiate between esports earnings and real money gaming. There is also no clear pathway today to formally register esports teams as entities within a defined structure," Agarwal said.

Players and organisations still lack comprehensive protections under a clear regulatory framework, Agarwal said and added that addressing these areas will be critical for the ecosystem to move from early structure to full legitimacy and long-term sustainability.

Bihar records first-ever structured masoor procurement

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Over 100 tonne of masoor dal have been procured at the minimum support price in Bihar under the first-ever structured pulses procurement initiative launched as part of the Aatmanirbhar Pulses Mission, the Union Food Ministry said on Thursday.

The procurement is being undertaken under the Price Support Scheme (PSS) of

2,926 tonnes of the two pulses as of April 22, an official statement said.

Procurement in Chhattisgarh has gained momentum through digitised farmer registration on the E-Samyukti portal, backed by extensive awareness campaigns on the ground.

A network of 85 Primary Agricultural Credit Society (PACS) centres is operational across districts including Dhamtari, Durg, Balod,



PM-AASHA (Pradhan Mantri Annadata Aay Sanrakshana Abhiyan) Yojana, marking a significant step in the Government's push towards self-reliance in pulse production.

In Chhattisgarh, the National Cooperative Consumers' Federation of India (NCCF) procured 9,039 tonnes of chana and masoor, while the National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India (NAFED) purchased

Balodabazar, Raipur, Raigarh, and Sarangarh. Operations are set to be expanded to Sarguja, Kondagaon, and Koriya.

In Bihar, NCCF has initiated organised procurement of masoor for the first time, with storage being facilitated through Warehouse Development and Regulatory Authority (WDRA)-approved warehouses operated in collaboration with the Central Warehousing Corporation.

FROM THE WORLD

US

Iran-linked oil tanker seized

The US military seized another tanker on Thursday associated with smuggling Iranian oil The US Defence Department said it seized the oil tanker Majestic X in the Indian Ocean. "We will continue global maritime enforcement to disrupt illicit networks and interdict vessels providing material support to Iran, wherever they operate," the Defence Department said. The seizure comes after Iran attacked three cargo ships Wednesday in the Strait of Hormuz, capturing two of them. The Defence Department released footage of the seizure of the vessel, showing US troops on the deck of the vessel. Ship-tracking data showed the Majestic X in the Indian Ocean between Sri Lanka and Indonesia, roughly the same location as the oil tanker Tifani, earlier seized by American forces.

PAKISTAN

PM's family gets warrant relief

A Pakistani court has suspended arrest warrants against Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's daughter and son-in-law in a corruption case, a court official said on Thursday. Judge Rana Arif of the Accountability Court, Lahore, suspended the arrest warrants against Rabia Imran and her husband Imran Ali Yousaf in the Punjab Saaf Pani Company mega corruption case on Wednesday, saying that every citizen has a right to a free and fair trial, the official said. The accountability court had issued perpetual warrants for their arrest in 2022 during the tenure of then-prime minister Imran Khan. Rabia and Yousuf had fled to the UK in 2022, and the court subsequently had declared them proclaimed offenders. "The PM's daughter and son-in-law told the court through their counsel that the arrest warrants could not be executed because they were abroad, but now they want to return to Pakistan. Therefore, they surrender themselves before the court and face the trial.

Lebanon condemns Israeli demolition of homes post-ceasefire

ABBY SEWELL ■ Beirut

In areas of southern Lebanon it has occupied since agreeing last week to a ceasefire with Hezbollah, the Israeli army has been destroying homes it says were used as outposts by the Iran-backed militant group. But the demolitions are happening on such a wide scale that residents, Lebanese officials and UN peacekeepers are increasingly worried that large numbers of people displaced by the latest war will have nowhere to return if the fragile truce holds. From a hill overlooking Beit Lif - about 4 km (2.5 mi) north of Lebanon's border with Israel 3 *Associated Press* journalists could see that the

village, once home to a few thousand people, had been almost entirely flattened. "They were demolishing it gradually until they reached the main square and now, as you can see, there are no more houses," said Hassan Sweidan, a resident of a neighboring village. Lebanese officials plan to raise the issue of widespread demolitions on Thursday when they hold ceasefire talks with their Israeli counterparts in Washington - part of the first direct negotiations between the two countries in decades. Because of security concerns and limited access, neither UN peacekeepers nor Lebanese officials have been able to conduct a detailed



survey of the villages where demolitions are taking place. But observers have described entire residential neighborhoods in multiple villages being systematically destroyed. On March 2, two

days after the US and Israel launched the war with Iran, Hezbollah entered the fray by firing missiles into northern Israel. The group had been under pressure by the Lebanese Government to

disarm following its previous war with Israel in 2024, but refused to do so. Israel responded with an intense bombing campaign and ground invasion of Lebanon that prompted hundreds of thousands of people to flee the southern part of the country. The fighting has killed around 2,300 people in Lebanon, including hundreds of women and children. The fighting was mostly halted by a 10-day ceasefire that began Friday. But both sides have carried out strikes since then. Hezbollah has justified its attacks in part by pointing to the Israeli military's destruction of houses. Israeli officials have said they intend to occupy parts of southern Lebanon, and the

military has issued maps of a "forward defense line" that extends several miles into Lebanon and encompasses dozens of villages whose residents have not been allowed to return. Following the announcement of the ceasefire, Israeli Defense Minister Israel Katz said this area had been "cleared of terrorists and weapons and is empty of citizens, and will continue to be cleared of terrorists' infrastructure, including the destruction of houses in Lebanese villages that border (Israel) and have become terrorists outposts in every sense." After the ceasefire went into effect, Sweidan returned to check on his home in the southern

Lebanese village of Yater. It is still intact. Because Sweidan's village overlooks neighboring Beit Lif, he has been able to observe Israeli army operations there. Despite damage from Israeli airstrikes during the war, most of Beit Lif was still standing on the first day of the ceasefire, he said. But on the second day, Israeli forces arrived with bulldozers, jackhammers and tanks. "We would come each day to see how much of the village was demolished," he said. Tilak Pokharel, a spokesperson for the U.S. peacekeeping force in southern Lebanon known as UNIFIL, said that peacekeepers "have observed demolitions taking place in several areas" since the truce. (AP)

Pak Minister, US discuss second round Iran talks

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi on Thursday met US Charge d'Affaires to Pakistan, Natalie Baker and discussed ongoing diplomatic efforts to hold a second round of US-Iran talks in Islamabad, according to an official statement. The meeting comes amid stepped-up diplomatic engagements aimed at bringing Tehran and Washington to the negotiating table, possibly by the weekend. Naqvi and Baker held an "important meeting" during which they exchanged detailed views on the latest regional situation and discussed diplomatic efforts related to the proposed second round of



Mohsin Naqvi

peace talks, the interior ministry said in a statement. Naqvi welcomed US President Donald Trump's initiative to extend the ceasefire, calling it a "welcome development" that made significant progress towards reducing tensions. "We also hope for positive progress

from Iran's side," the minister said. Naqvi and Baker emphasised the need to maintain diplomatic channels for a lasting resolution to the West Asia conflict. According to the statement, Naqvi told Baker that Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Chief of Defence Forces (CDF) Field Marshal Asim Munir were making "all-out efforts at every level" to facilitate a peaceful outcome. "It is hoped that both parties will give a chance to a diplomatic and peaceful solution," the minister said. The meeting, the second between the two this week, took place amid uncertainty over the talks, with Islamabad under tight security for the proposed engage-

ment. On Monday, Naqvi held separate meetings with Baker and Iran's Ambassador to Pakistan Reza Amiri Moghadam, to discuss arrangements for the second round of Islamabad Talks. Trump on Wednesday extended the ceasefire with Iran indefinitely at the request of Pakistan to give Tehran's leadership more time to prepare a unified proposal to end the war. The dramatic announcement came just hours before the two-week ceasefire was set to expire. Iran's semi-official Tasnim news agency reported that Tehran has not issued any official statement confirming its agreement to extend the ceasefire. (PTI)

Lebanese journalist killed in Israeli strike

BASSEM MROUE/SARAH EL DEEB ■ Beirut

A Lebanese journalist was killed on Wednesday in an Israeli airstrike on a house in southern Lebanon where she had taken cover while reporting on the Israel-Hezbollah war. Her body was only retrieved from the rubble hours later, rescue workers said. The daily Al-Akhbar newspaper says its reporter Amal Khalil was killed in the southern village of al-Tiri. Khalil had been covering the conflict in Lebanon between Israel and the Lebanese Hezbollah militant group that resumed in early March, in the shadow of the US-Israeli war in Iran. She took cover in the house in al-Tiri after an earlier Israeli airstrike hit near the car she was traveling in with another colleague. The Lebanese health ministry said the first strike killed two people. A second Israeli strike then hit the house in al-Tiri where Khalil and her colleague Zeinab Faraj had taken cover. At first, rescue workers were able to



Lebanese journalist Amal Khalil

get to Faraj, who was seriously wounded, and retrieve the bodies of two killed in the first airstrike. But they were fired on by Israeli forces so they were forced to halt attempts to reach Khalil, the ministry said. Khalil remained under the rubble for hours before the Lebanese army, civil defense and the Lebanese Red Cross were able to get to the scene hours later. (AP)

US Navy Secretary is leaving in latest departure of a top defence leader

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Washington

Navy Secretary John Phelan is leaving his job, the Pentagon abruptly announced , the first head of a military service to depart during President Donald Trump's second term but just the latest top defense leader to step down or be ousted. No reason was given for the unexpected departure of the Navy's top civilian official, coming as the sea service has imposed a blockade of Iranian ports and is targeting ships linked to Tehran around the world during a tenuous ceasefire in the war. Another Trump loyalist is taking over



as acting head of the Navy: Undersecretary Hung Cao, a 25-year Navy combat veteran who ran unsuccessful campaigns for the US Senate and House in Virginia. Phelan's departure is the latest in a series of shakeups of top leadership at the Pentagon, coming just weeks after Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth fired the Army's top uniformed officer, General

Randy George. Hegseth also has fired several other top generals, admirals and defense leaders since taking office last year. The firings began in February 2025, when Hegseth removed military leaders, including Adm. Lisa Franchetti, the Navy's top uniformed officer, and General Jim Slife, the No. 2 leader at the Air Force. Trump also fired Gen. Charles "CQ" Brown Jr as chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Showing how sudden the latest move was, Phelan had addressed a large crowd of sailors and industry professionals at the Navy's annual conference in Washington and spoke with reporters about his agenda.

Pahlavi splattered with red liquid in Berlin

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Berlin

Iran's exiled Crown Prince Reza Pahlavi was splattered with red liquid on Thursday as he left a building in Berlin, Germany. Pahlavi had just departed a news briefing, during which he criticised the ceasefire between the Unites States and Iran, when the incident occurred outside Germany's federal press conference building. He then waved to his supporters and got into a car that drove away. The alleged perpetrator was immediately detained by police. Pahlav, 65, is the son of Iran's former shah, who was so widely hated that millions took to the streets in 1979 to



force him from power. Nevertheless, Pahlavi is trying to position himself as a player in his country's future, though it's unclear how much support he has in Iran after he has been in exile for nearly 50 years. Pahlavi, who was not invited to meet with any

Government representatives during his visit to Berlin, argued Thursday that the ceasefire agreement assumes the Iranian Government's behaviour will change and "you're going to deal with people who all of a sudden have become pragmatists." "I don't see that

happening," he said. "I'm not saying that diplomacy should not be given a chance, but I think diplomacy has been given enough chance." Pahlavi is jockeying for a return to power should the Shiite theocracy fall and has supported the US-Israeli military intervention in the West Asia. Pahlavi in Berlin called on Europeans to do more to support Iranian people fighting for democracy. He claimed 19 political prisoners were executed by Iranian authorities in the past two weeks and another 20 people have been sentenced to death. "Will the free world do something, or watch the slaughter in silence?" Pahlavi said.

Post-election violence killed 518 in Tanzania: Govt inquiry

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dar es Salam

At least 518 people died in last year's postelection violence in Tanzania, which happened amid an internet shutdown, a commission formed to investigate said on Thursday. Thousands of people were injured in the violence, with more than 800 people having gunshot wounds. The commission chairman, Mohamed Chande Othman, said that the number of deaths was likely to be higher, because some families buried their loved ones without taking their bodies to morgues. Tanzania

experienced postelection violence on October 29, after young people took to the streets, accusing the Government of silencing the opposition, as the country's main opposition party leader remained in prison for treason and the presidential candidate for the second-largest opposition party was barred from running. The internet was shut down in the country for days, a move that President Samia Suluhu Hassan later apologised to the diplomatic community for and promised would never happen again. Hassan was seeking a second term in office after serving out the

term of her predecessor, John Magufuli, after he died in office. Hassan won with 97 per cent of the vote, and some international observers said the election fell short of a free and fair vote. Othman recommended that a further investigation be conducted on the use of firearms, as some of the witnesses told the commission that their loved ones were shot while sitting inside their houses. Since the violence, 245 people remain unaccounted for, and 39 families reported having seen the bodies of their loved ones in morgues before they later disappeared.

Nine killed in Balochistan mine attack

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Nine workers were killed when militants attacked a copper and gold mine site in Pakistan's restive Balochistan province, police said on Thursday. The attack took place at the copper and gold project operated by National Resources Limited (NRL) in the Chagai district's Darigwan site on Wednesday evening, when the workers were finishing their shift, a senior police official said. "It was a targeted attack and carried out at a time when workers were winding up their shift," the official said. He said that the bodies were taken to Prince Fahad Hospital in Dalbandin. The mining company confirmed the attack in a statement but did not mention casualties. It said security forces, including the Frontier Corps, responded promptly, secured the area, and launched a clearance operation. The statement said the NRL remained "fully committed to the development and empowerment of local communities in Balochistan, with a strong focus on



improving livelihoods and contributing to Balochistan's economy". It said 90 per cent of its workforce at the Darigwan site comprised individuals from Balochistan. The mining company recently reported discoveries of copper, gold, lead and zinc deposits. This is not the first time that militants have attacked construction sites in the province, where workers mostly from other provinces were targeted.

US still delivering weapons to Ukraine, says Zelenskyy

HANNA ARHIROVA/SAMYA KULLAB ■ Kyiv

US weapons deliveries to Ukraine haven't stopped despite the Iran war, and Ukrainian long-range strikes continue to hammer Russian oil production and manufacturing plants, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Thursday. "Of course, we are hitting what is painful for Russia, and it is very painful," Zelenskyy said in voice messages to reporters. He said that Russian losses in the strikes have reached tens of billions of dollars.

It wasn't possible to independently verify Zelenskyy's comments, but Russian officials have reported that attacks have struck infrastructure in regions more than 1,000 kilometers (600 miles) inside Russia. While Russia presses its all-out invasion, which began on February 24, 2022, Ukraine is using its domestically developed drone and missile technology to strike Russian territory. The Ukrainian military also uses American-made Patriot air defence systems to stop Russian missile attacks on Ukraine's territory. "We see that the Russians do not want to stop - they are hitting our energy sector and our people. We will respond," Zelenskyy said. Ukraine's fight against Russia's bigger army drew renewed praise from Prince Harry, who arrived in Kyiv on



Thursday for his third visit in a year. Ukrainians have demonstrated "strength not just in bravery and capability, but in unity, in trust," he said in a speech to a Kyiv security conference. Ukraine "continues to hold together, and hold together you must," he said. The Duke of Sussex stepped off a train in Kyiv's main station after an overnight journey from Poland, which is the only way to travel to the Ukrainian capital. It wasn't clear whether Harry would meet with Zelenskyy, who was due to attend a summit of European Union leaders in Cyprus on Thursday evening. Hours before Harry arrived, three people were killed and 10 were wounded in a Russian drone attack on the central Ukrainian city of Dnipro, according to Oleksandr Hanzha, the head of the regional military administration. A 13-story building and an administrative building were damaged in the strike, Hanzha said on the Telegram messaging app. (AP)

West Asia conflict disrupts medicine access in rural Sudan

SAM MEDNICK ■ Qoz Nafisa (Sudan)



spacing out his medicine for glaucoma, worried he won't be able to find more or afford it when he does. Money was already an issue because of the war at home, he said. "Now we have the problem of the war in the West Asia.

It's just made things worse," he said. Aid groups say the Iran war has cut off vital shipping routes, upending their ability to get food and medicine to millions of people around the world in need.

The standoff between the United States and Iran has essentially shut down the Strait of Hormuz, and other routes from strategic hubs such as Dubai also have been impacted. Transport costs have spiked with higher fuel and insurance rates, further straining the ability to deliver supplies. The United Nations says there's been up to a 20 per cent cost increase on shipments, along with delays, as goods are rerouted. The International Rescue Committee, which supports the clinic where Awad gets some of his medicines, said about \$130,000 worth of pharmaceuticals intended for Sudan was stranded in

Dubai for weeks and only now is making its way there. The IRC says medicines and supplies such as antibiotics, painkillers and stethoscopes that were supposed to be flown from the United Arab Emirates to Port Sudan were instead transported by road to neighboring Oman and then flown out. US President Donald Trump this week extended the fragile ceasefire with Iran, but aid groups worry little will change. "There's still a real lag in the system. Shipments remain blocked or delayed, and that's deeply worrying," said Madiha Raza, associate director for global public

affairs and communications for IRC. Sudan has widely been described as facing the world's worst humanitarian crisis, and Raza said any delay in delivering food, medicine and fuel has devastating consequences. For the roughly 5,000 people who rely on the public health clinic that the IRC supports in Qoz Nafisa, some now must search at other clinics and spend their own money, which they often don't have. During a visit by AP journalists on Wednesday, clinic staff said that since the war with Iran began at the end of February they've been struggling to meet demand. (AP)

Militants kill 11 people in Nigeria

HARUNA UMAR
■ Maiduguri

Islamic militants attacked a remote village in northeast-ern Nigeria overnight, killing 11 people and leaving two critically injured, local officials said. It was the latest violence in Africa's most populous country that has long been battling a complex security crisis.

The attack took place late in Pubagu, a community in a remote area on the fringes of Sambisa forest in Borno State, the epicenter of Nigeria's long fight against an Islamic insurgency.

Villagers said they buried the victims on Wednesday and attributed the attack to the extremist Boko Haram



group. The local council chairman, Mwada Saidu Uba, said that the village had previously been considered a safe haven.

"Pubagu is one of the locations in our council area

that had never suffered such an attack until yesterday," he said after the funerals.

The two injured were receiving treatment at a nearby hospital, he added. Usman Rumirgo, a local

ward official, said the assailants set several houses ablaze before leaving the area.

Vulnerable rural communities regularly come under fire from Islamic extremists and bandits who take advantage of Nigeria's vast rural areas and security gaps. Among the most prominent Islamic militant groups active in Nigeria are Boko Haram and its breakaway faction, affiliated with the Islamic State group and is known as Islamic State West Africa Province, or ISWAP.

There is also the IS-linked Lakurawa, as well as other "bandit" groups that specialize in kidnapping for ransom and illegal mining. (AP)

Hackers breach Sri Lanka's finance ministry system

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Sri Lanka's Finance Ministry has said that the computer system of the External Resources Department has been hacked by cyber hackers who gained unauthorised access and carried out a theft involving a foreign currency payment.

The Ministry of Finance, Planning and Economic Development said it has already lodged complaints with law enforcement agencies and other relevant institutions regarding the theft.

"Cyber hackers have gained unauthorised access to the computer system of an External Resources



Department within the institution," the ministry statement said.

The statement came to be issued after the opposition claimed that \$2.5 million of treasury funds had gone to an account other than the relevant foreign debt repayment account of Australian origin.

Pope ends Africa visit with mass in Equatorial Guinea



NICOLE WINFIELD
■ Malabo (Equatorial Guinea)

Pope Leo XIV wrapped up his African odyssey on Thursday with a final Mass in Equatorial Guinea, bringing to an end one of the newest papal trips in the history of popes on the road, thanks to his extraordinary back-and-forth with President Donald Trump.

A powerful rainstorm drenched the Malabo sports stadium and the estimated 30,000 people who gathered before dawn for Leo's farewell liturgy. But the deluge let up before Leo arrived in his covered popemobile for a romp through the deafening crowd. Leo was leaving after an 11-day, four-nation voyage that took him from Algeria in the north of Africa to Angola in the south and Cameroon in

between. Over that time, Leo covered more than 17,700 km on 18 flights, including three on Wednesday alone that saw him crisscross Equatorial Guinea from the west coast to the far east border with Gabon and back again.

Nearly everywhere Leo went, history's first US pope received a raucous welcome, especially in the farther away places that had never had a pope visit. Popes have been travelling the world since Pope Paul VI made the first modern foreign visit in 1964 to Jordan and Israel. But it was St John Paul II who revolutionized the papacy with his globetrotting papacy that took him on 104 foreign trips over a quarter century, many with the multination itinerary on which Leo's trip seemed modelled. (AP)

UK-France seal new deal to curb migrant boats

SYLVIE CORBET
■ Paris

Britain and France are set to unveil a new multimillion-euro deal Thursday aimed at reducing the number of migrants crossing the English Channel in small boats, with increased police patrols and enhanced surveillance in northern France.

Home Secretary Shabana Mahmood and French Interior Minister Laurent Nunez are to sign the three-year agreement during a joint visit to the region.

Under the deal, the UK will provide 500 million pounds to strengthen measures in northern France, with an additional 160 million pounds depending on the success of new tactics to curb Channel crossings. If those efforts fail, the additional funding will be halted after one year, the Home Office said.

The agreement provides for boosting the number of officers deployed on the ground from 907 now to 1,392 for the 2026-2029 period, along with the creation of an additional police unit dedicated to combating irregular migration, funded by France, the French Interior Ministry said.

It will also include the deployment of new technologies aimed at reducing departures of so-called "taxi boats," the term authorities use for small motorised vessels, usually inflatable, used by smugglers to pick up migrants along long stretches of the northern French coast. Unlike boats that



migrants carry into the water themselves, "taxi boats" typically set off largely empty from secluded coastal areas and pick up migrants at pre-arranged meeting points on beaches.

The deal also expands surveillance capabilities through drones, helicopters and electronic monitoring, to better prevent crossing attempts.

UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer said cooperation between the two countries had "already stopped tens of thousands of crossings" and that "this historic agreement means we can go further - ramping up intelligence, surveillance and boots on the ground to protect Britain's borders." So far this year, arrivals in the UK have fallen by more than half compared with the same period in 2025, according to the French interior ministry. Police operations led to the arrest of 480 smugglers last year, it said.

A large share of the resources provided under the deal will be deployed from early summer, traditionally the busiest period for crossing attempts as weather conditions improve. (AP)

Ex-Philippine president to face trial on charges of crimes against humanity

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ The Hague

Judges at the International Criminal Court on Thursday confirmed crimes against humanity charges against former Philippine president Rodrigo Duterte for deadly anti-drugs crackdowns he allegedly oversaw while in office.

A three-judge panel found unanimously there were "substantial grounds" to believe the ex-leader was responsible for dozens of murders, first as mayor of the southern Philippine city of Davao and later when he was president from 2016 to 2022. Duterte, 80, was arrested in the Philippines last year. He denies the charges



against him.

In their 50-page decision, judges found that the evidence shows that Duterte "developed, disseminated and implemented" a policy "to neutralise alleged crim-

inals". According to prosecutors, police and hit squad members carried out dozens of murders at Duterte's behest starting in 2011, motivated by the promise of money or to

2 trains collide in Denmark, leaving 5 critically injured

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Copenhagen

Two trains collided in Denmark early on Thursday, leaving five people critically injured in what police called a major incident.

The collision occurred around 6.30 am near Hillerød, about 40 kilometers (25 miles) north of Copenhagen. Roughly a dozen other people have minor injuries, according to the Greater Copenhagen Fire Department.

Everyone has been evacuated out of the trains, according to a spokesperson for the North Zealand



police. Officials originally said four people were critically injured but revised that figure hours after the crash.

It was not immediately clear whether the train's drivers were among the victims. Investigators are looking into what caused the collision.

Photos from the scene show the front ends of the trains smashed, though both remained upright on the tracks. The mayor of the nearby town of Gribskov, Trine Egetved, in a post on Facebook, said some of the injured were flown to the hospital.

Estonian FM visits Vietnam to boost trade ties

ANIRUDDHA GHOSAL
■ Hanoi (Vietnam)

Estonia's Foreign Minister Margus Tsahkna met Vietnamese Prime Minister Le Minh Hung on Wednesday and said his country aims to deepen cooperation with Vietnam in trade, technology and digital transformation. Relations between Vietnam and Estonia have accelerated in recent years and the two countries signed agreements on digital cooperation in 2025.

Estonia's GDP accounts for just 0.2 per cent of the European Union's total, but it punches above its weight in digital expertise and e-governance innovation. It is offering that expertise to Vietnam as the Southeast Asian export powerhouse pursues reforms aimed at making it a high-income economy by 2045. Cooperation on digitalization of services could help Vietnam reduce bureaucracy, improve transparency



and lower costs, Tsahkna said.

"It is much more quicker for citizens to be part of public sector services," he told The Associated Press in Hanoi, adding that Vietnam had proposed an education cooperation agreement.

Hung, the prime minister, asked Estonia to urge the European Union to ratify an Investment Protection Agreement and support efforts to lift the European Commission's "yellow card"

that restricts imports of Vietnamese seafood exports for illegal fishing, said state media.

Tsahkna said Estonia could serve as a gateway for Vietnamese businesses to Europe, while Vietnam offers Estonia a larger market and a foothold in Southeast Asia. "For us, Vietnam is one of the priority countries in the region," he said. He said the meetings in Vietnam were also an opportunity to convey Europe's view of why it sees Russia as an "existential threat".

Hanoi and Moscow have had diplomatic relations since 1950 and Vietnam has maintained a neutral stance regarding the war in Ukraine, advocating peace but avoiding direct criticism of Russia. Tsahkna said Estonia's outreach to Vietnam and Southeast Asia is driven by geopolitical pressures and economic opportunity, as US President Donald Trump's criticism of European defense spending and tariff tensions compel Europe to look outward. (AP)

Turkish parliament passes bill to restrict social media access for kids under-15

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Istanbul

Turkish lawmakers passed a bill late on Wednesday that includes restricting access to social media platforms for children under 15, State media reported.

The legislation is the latest in a global trend to protect young people from dangerous online activity.

Its passage comes a week after a 14-year-old boy killed nine students and a teacher at a middle school in Kahramanmaraş, southern Türkiye, in a gun attack.

Police are investigating the online activity of the perpetrator, who also died, in a bid to uncover his moti-



vation for the attack. The bill will force social media platforms to install age-verification systems, provide parental control tools and require companies to rapidly respond to content deemed harmful, the State-run Anadolu news agency said. Turkish President Recep

Samsung workers rally in South Korea, demanding higher pay

Tayyip Erdogan must now accept the bill within 15 days for it to pass into law. He spoke in the wake of the Kahramanmaraş killings of the need for to mitigate the online risks to children's safety and privacy.

"We are living in a period where some digital sharing applications are corrupting our children's minds and social media platforms have, to put it bluntly, become cesspools," he said in a televised address Monday.

The main opposition party - the Republican People's Party, or CHP - has criticised the proposal, saying children should be protected "not with bans but with rights-based policies." (AP)



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Pyeongtaek

Thousands of Samsung Electronics workers rallied Thursday at its computer chip complex in Pyeongtaek, South Korea, demanding higher bonuses and threatening to strike as booming demand for artificial intelligence drives up memory-chip profits.

Holding signs and waving banners, the workers gathered at a factory compound amid a heavy police presence, shouting "make compensation transparent and remove maximum limits on bonuses!" Union officials said about 40,000 members participated in the protest. Police did not immediately provide a crowd estimate.

The rally came hours after Samsung's cross-town rival, SK Hynix, posted an all time high in quarterly revenue and operating profit for the January-March quarter, a jump it attributed to expanding global investments in data centres and other AI infrastructure that drove up the demands for its memory chips. (AP)

Russian oil to Slovakia resumes flowing through a pipeline that crosses Ukraine

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bratislava (Slovakia)

The flow of Russian oil to Slovakia through the Druzhba pipeline that crosses Ukraine has resumed, Slovak Economy Minister Denisa Sakova said on Thursday, a breakthrough in an issue that has caused a major diplomatic spat in Europe.

The development is expected to unblock a large financial assistance package for war-ravaged Ukraine.

Populist Slovak Prime Minister Robert Fico welcomed the development, calling it "good news."

"Let's hope a serious relation between Ukraine and the European Union has

been established," Fico said. He thanked all those involved in solving the issue, including the European Commission and Hungary.

Hungary and Slovakia were locked in a feud with Ukraine since Russian oil deliveries to Hungary and Slovakia through the pipeline were halted in January after the pipeline was damaged.

Ukrainian officials blamed the damage on Russian drone attacks. Hungary's nationalist Prime Minister Viktor Orban, who was recently defeated in an election, accused Ukraine of deliberately delaying repairs - an allegation that Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy denied. Fico said



PROSPECT

Govt extends tenure of Managing Directors of BoI, Bank of Baroda for 3 years



Rajneesh Karnatak, Bank of India Debadatta Chand, Bank of Baroda

The Government has extended the tenure of Managing Directors of Bank of India (BoI) and Bank of Baroda (BoB) for three years beyond their current terms. According to officials, the Government has extended the term of Rajneesh Karnatak, MD and CEO of BoI, for three years, effective April 29, 2026. Karnatak was appointed as MD and CEO of the bank in 2023 for three years.

Besides, the Appointment Committee of the Cabinet, headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, also approved the extension of Debadatta Chand, MD and CEO of BoB, for three years, effective July 1, 2026. However, the Government has not yet taken a view on extension with regard to UCO Bank MD and CEO Ashwani Kumar, whose three-year term is also coming to an end on June 1, 2026. The Appointment Committee of the Cabinet has also extended the term of Ashutosh Choudhary as executive director of Indian Bank for another three years.

India’s voice resonates at Commonwealth summit

The fifth edition of the Commonwealth Trade and Investment Summit opened at the historic Mansion House in the City of London, with India emerging as a key voice in discussions on global growth, innovation and leadership. The two-day summit, organised by the Commonwealth Enterprise and Investment Council, brought together Heads of Government, ministers, and senior business leaders from across the 56 Commonwealth nations.

With a collective population of 2.7 billion, the event represents a powerful platform for collaboration, innovation, and economic partnership across emerging and established markets.Features of the summit under the theme “Commonwealth Solutions to Global Challenges,” the summit featured high-level discussions on artificial intelligence, sustainable energy, infrastructure, health technologies, creative industries, and the evolving global financial landscape, alongside closed-door roundtables to encourage actionable dialogue. Among the distinguished speakers, renowned global humanitarian, transformation pioneer and spiritual leader Maitreya Dadashreeji was invited to represent India. He delivered a powerful discourse titled India – Leadership Through Change to Prosperity. Reinforcing India's spiritual legacy, Maitreya Dadashreeji called for a shift from power-driven to purpose-driven leadership, inspiring collective action toward a more peaceful, united, and prosperous world.

Distancing from conventional policy dialogue Distancing from conventional policy dialogue, Maitreya Dadashreeji brought a deeply human and spiritual perspective to the summit. Emphasising that true progress stems from inner stability and emotional alignment, he highlighted the urgent need to reconnect with the essence of humanity beyond divisions of race, religion, and region.

National conference of AIBEA adjourned amid disruptions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The 30th national conference of the All India Bank Employees' Association (AIBEA) in Bengaluru started on April 19 was impacted by disruptions, leading to an indefinite adjournment of the delegates' session. The Delegate session of the AIBEA adjourned without completing the election agenda, on April 22. Members demanded the removal of long time office bearers CH Venkatachalam and Rambabu. They demanded P R Mehta be elected, said delegates.

Delegates said that the 30th conference of All India Bank Employees' Association will be remembered as one of the saddest moments in its history. Due to unfortunate and unforeseen developments, the proceedings could not be brought to a proper conclusion and had to be adjourned sine die.

This unexpected turn of



events calls for deep introspection, reflection, and collective resolve. It is a moment to reassess, learn, and strengthen the unity and purpose that have long defined the organization.

The conference brought together delegates, office bearers, and participants from across the country.

The multi-day event included discussions, celebrations marking the union's 80th Foundation Day, and key deliberations on organisational matters.

A circular dated late night on April 22 said that a section of participants started disrupting the proceedings and hence the presidium

adjourned the proceedings.

"In this background, the Office Bearers met and unanimously decided that having regard to the continued disruption of the proceedings and the announcement of the presidium for adjournment, the Delegate Session of the Conference be adjourned sine-die until further notice," the circular said.

The circular added that this decision was duly informed to the delegates and observers and thus the Delegates' Session stood adjourned.

The circular said that the 30th Conference of AIBEA commenced as scheduled on the April 19 at Bengaluru. General Secretary CH

Venkatachalam's Report was presented and placed for discussion. In the evening there was an impressive and colourful procession followed by inaugural public session.

On April 20, the 80th Founding Day of AIBEA, the happy occasion was celebrated with gaiety by over 3300 participants with various programmes - blood donation by 194 comrades, honouring the former office bearers of AIBEA, special lecture on Constitution and Democracy, honouring various achievers, release of publications, cultural program, etc.

On April 21, the Delegates' Session was continued and 55 delegates participated in the discussions. On April 22 morning the Delegates' Session resumed for continuing the discussions and to complete the remaining agenda. Unfortunately, a section of participants started disturbing the proceedings and hence the presidium adjourned the proceedings, said delegates.

Noida Authority provides medical insurance coverage to 4,800 workers



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

The Chief Executive Officer of the Noida Authority has granted approval for medical insurance coverage for approximately 4,800 workers provided to the Authority, to be provided through the State Bank of India General Insurance Company.

This historic decision to extend medical facilities to personnel supplied through labor contractors was approved by the Board of Directors during the 215th Board Meeting of the Noida Authority, held on October 26, 2024. Under this scheme, up to five dependents of each supplied worker will be eligi-

ble to avail medical facilities with an annual coverage limit of ₹5 lakh. A premium of ₹10,000 per annum per worker will be paid to the State Bank of India General Insurance Company through the labor supply agency.

Currently, approximately 4,800 personnel supplied through labor contractors are employed at the Noida Authority. Following the revision of the eligibility ceiling for ESIC/medical facilities by the ESIC Department to ₹21,000, all such personnel at the Noida Authority had fallen outside the scope of ESIC/medical coverage; consequently, these workers had been persistently demanding the provision of medical facilities.

World’s first fully integrated agentic AI dispatcher Pilot launched

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

FarEye, the global leader in last-mile delivery, on Thursday announced the launch of PILOT — a groundbreaking vertical AI product designed to autonomously manage the end-to-end day of a logistics dispatcher with Human-In-The-Loop (HITL) governance. It will reduce the logistic time from 10 hours to 60 minutes only. Because PILOT replaces the manual grind of last-mile dispatch by autonomously orchestrating across 11 specialized AI agents — planning routes, managing drivers, recovering failed deliveries, and reconciling invoices, end to end.

PILOT has been launched in the presence of prominent stakeholders in a day long



event in Noida on Thursday.

On the occasion of Lauch of PILOT, FarEye's Co-Founder & CPTO, Gaurav Srivastava said in an industry where dispatchers typically spend 10 hours a day firefighting manual errors across multiple systems, PILOT reduces active human labor to just 60 minutes while driving a 95 percent reduction in dispatcher hours. "The dispatcher is the most underserved role in logistics, burdened by

spreadsheets while carrying the entire operation," he added.

"PILOT is the AI co-pilot they deserve and the financial edge organizations need. While traditional firms pay a 'Legacy Tax' of manual routing and high headcount, PILOT-enabled businesses achieve a 17.5% reduction in cost-per-delivery and allow for 3-5x greater productivity from dispatchers." Srivastava added.

POWERGRID commemorates birth anniversary of Dr BR Ambedkar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID), a Maharatna PSU under Ministry of Power commemorated the birth anniversary of Bharat Ratna Dr BR Ambedkar across its establishments spread throughout the country. Dr Yatindra Dwivedi, Director (Personnel) chaired a session which was attended by KG Verma, former Joint Secretary, Department of Personnel & Training (DoP&T), senior officials from POWERGRID and their families.

Floral tributes were offered, reaffirming the organisation's commitment to Dr Ambedkar's ideals of liberty, equality, fraternity, social justice, and inclusive develop-



ment. Various competitions such as speech and quiz contests were organised for the children of employees, thereby reinforcing the significance of Dr Ambedkar's ideals amongst the next generation. The ceremony also featured reflections on Dr Ambedkar's contributions to nation-building and underscored organisation's initiatives of promoting diversity, employee welfare, and community development.

As of March 31, POWER-GRID has commissioned and is operating 291 Sub-Stations and more than 1,84,960 km transmission lines and 6,24,016 MVA of transformation capacity. With the adoption of the latest technological tools and techniques, enhanced use of automation and digital solutions, POWER-GRID has been able to maintain an average transmission system availability of more than 99.84%.

DAILY SUDOKU

		7		8		5		6
5				2		7	3	
	9	6			7		4	
			9			6		7
		5				4		
7		3			1			
	7		2			3	6	
	8	1		7				2
6		2		9		1		

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HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

SOLUTION (23.04.26)								
5	6	3	8	4	2	9	7	1
1	9	2	5	7	6	3	8	4
7	4	8	9	3	1	2	6	5
9	3	6	2	1	8	4	5	7
2	7	4	6	5	3	8	1	9
8	5	1	4	9	7	6	2	3
6	1	9	3	8	5	7	4	2
3	2	7	1	6	4	5	9	8
4	8	5	7	2	9	1	3	6

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DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | APRIL 24, 2026

1			2		3		4		5		6
					7						
		8		9							
10						11		12		13	
			14			15		16			
17	18				19		20				
				21							
			22					23	24		25
26		27						28			
29						30					
						31					
32											
						33					

SOLUTION (23.04.26)

ACROSS
1, Smash
6, Psalm
9, Mi-racle
10, I-slam
11, A-ward
12,5, Fa-l-l-in
13, Fa-l-lacy
15, Cue
17, Op-us
18, B-leeps
19, Ar-ray
20, Twenty
22, Vera
24, Had
25, Fa-RADA-y
26, Fatal
27, Attic
28, Siltin
29, Sh-all-ot
30, Grate
31, Lying
DOWN
2, Mishap
3, Smalls
4, H-I'm
5, Sally
6, Pla-in-l-y (nil)
7, Sewn
8, Larr-up
12, Scar-y
13, F-or-th
14, Lu-red
15, Ceded
16, Essay
18, Banal
19, Attache
21, Wa-l-ter
22, Vanity
(Fair)
23, Rati-On
25, FA-ult
26, F-is-t
28, Sol

- ACROSS**
- 1 Dutch courage? (6)
7 Evict from a girl's home (8)
8 Surface extent of a square amphitheatre (4)
10 Not fit to be part of the business (6)
11 Is available in tins, perhaps, if you demand (6)
14 There can be only one winner (3)
16 Land of liberated laity (5)
17 Turn red, almost, with all that blood (4)
19 It's paid to many an individual on the 4th of July (5)
21 Leaves a contribution for the salad (5)
- DOWN**
- 1 Bent on milking the applause? (6)
2 How often to have hot cereal on Tuesday (6)
3 Made up with cheese (4)
4 Pet arrangement in Spain for the Spanish (7)
5 Her mother has a strange air (5)
6 Sort of larceny associated with cash (5)
8 How one may travel in seafaring (4)
9 Sooner than get here breathless (3)
12 Hardly the place to live in style! (3)
13 Was unaware of breaking step going round the corner (5)
- 22 Deeply distressed, all to pieces (3,2)
23 Shoots for trophies (4)
26 Points to a piece of work by a Spaniard (5)
28 He's a bit decadent (3)
29 Between cigarette ends, the band will fawn or grovel (6)
30 I leave a fighting man to form a union (6)
31 They have beaks (or hooters)? (4)
32 Foretells a woman's secret in the newspapers (8)
33 He's the boss, dear fellow (3,3)

- 15 As an officer, he has his own chair (5)
18 Peripheral tour arranged around mid-September (5)
19 Basis of wrestling? (3)
20 A little drink with a pin-up (3)
21 His dark deeds needn't be at night (7)
22 Deceive a man of conviction (3)
23 Looking sickly, paid about £50 (6)
24 But they could be evens! (4)
25 A good talking to (6)
26 Opportunity to use vision? (5)
27 Finer resort and tourist centre (5)
28 Female dairy supplier (3)
30 It's fair to use the same word twice (2)

Bhagwant University’s computer department organise industrial tour

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Department of Computer Science & Engineering and Computer Applications at Bhagwant University, Ajmer, successfully organized an industrial visit on April 20. The visit aimed to expose students to real-world industrial practices and connect their theoretical learning with practical experience. Students participated enthusiastically and gained valuable insights into various aspects of the modern IT industry. The program was conducted under the guidance of Vice Chancellor Prof. (Dr) V K Sharma and Pro Vice Chancellor Prof. (Dr.) RK Ghai, whose support and motivation ensured its success. They also highlighted the importance of industrial exposure in shaping students' careers.

The event was graced by Registrar Prof. (Dr) Ajay Kumar Sharma, Engineering Director Prof. (Dr) Sudhir Rajguru, Assistant Director Dr Komal Alawani, Dr Munna Verma, and



Dr Amit Chaudhary. The visit was effectively coordinated by Arun Kumar Mishra (Head of Department), Dr Manoj Kumar Sharma, Engg. Ajhar Ali, Engg. Dharmendra Shaktawat, and Engg. Ishita Jain. Chairman Dr Anil Singh and Vice Chairperson Dr Asha Singh congratulated the organising team and expressed their expectation for the continued planning of such initiatives in the future.

Naveen Kunwal, Director of CRM Landing Software Pvt. Ltd., emphasised the importance of skill development over traditional education. Salesforce Developer Firoz Khan provided insights into the Salesforce platform and its growing relevance in the IT sector, guiding students toward careers in CRM and cloud technologies.

AI Developer Varsha Dubey

discussed applications, future scope, and significance of AI, encouraging students to pursue it as a career and stay updated with emerging technologies. Network Support Engineer Mohammad Saeed highlighted the critical role of networking in IT infrastructure and the importance of strong fundamentals. Students including Kushal Bagdi, Paritosh Sharma, Devansh, Aastha, Ankit, and Hemendra shared their experiences, noting that visit enhanced their practical knowledge and helped resolve their queries.

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
Tender No.ENG/P10/1649/
Green Ammonia/2025/328 Dt.13.04.2026
DEVELOPMENT OF JETTY WITH ALLIED
FACILITIES FOR HANDLING GREEN HYDROGEN/
AMMONIA & OTHER LIQUID CARGO ON BOT BASIS
INVITATION OF REQUEST FOR QUALIFICATION
(RFQ) & REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)
Paradip Port Authority (PPA) invites bids
from interested Bidders in accordance
with the RFQ & RFP documents which
may be downloaded from the CPP Portal
(https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app).
Last date & time of submission of Bids
is 26.06.2026 till 1400 hours.
Sd/- Executive Engineer (C)
Project Implementation Office
Paradip Port Authority
PPA/PR/07/2026-2027 dtd. 22.04.2026

MADHYA PRADESH INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
(Government of Madhya Pradesh Undertaking)
SECRETARIAT FOR SINGLE WINDOW SYSTEM
21, Arera Hills, Bhopal-462011, M.P. (India), CIN : U51102MP1977SGC001392
E-mail : helpdesk@mpidc.co.in, Web. : www.invest.mp.gov.in Tel. : 0755-2571830, 2575618, 3523505
Ref. No. : MPIDC/LM/SWS-RFP/2026/NIT-04-01
No. 52/MPIDC/LM/NIT-04-01 Dated : 23.04.2026

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) FOR ALLOTMENT OF INDUSTRIAL PLOTS THROUGH E-BIDDING

Department of Industrial Policy and Investment Promotion (DIPIP), Government of Madhya Pradesh through M.P. Industrial Development Corporation Limited (A Govt. of M.P. Undertaking) has invited Online Tender cum Auction (E-forward auction) for allotment of available Industrial Plots at **Burhanpur, Dhar, Jabua, Ratlam, Shajapur and Sehore District** through NIT-04-01. The Process of which will start on the <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> from **27.04.2026**

1. To participate in e-bidding, it is necessary to have Class 3 Digital Signature. Detailed information about rules, procedure and plots etc. can also be viewed on MPIDC website - <https://invest.mp.gov.in>
2. Please refer to the Tender documents before proceeding with the application.
3. Corrigendum related to e-bidding process, if any, will not be published in the newspaper, it will be uploaded on <https://mptenders.gov.in> portal.
M.P. Madhyam/125460/2026

EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

BRIEFLY

Barcelona clinch women’s Spanish league title



Barcelona won its seventh straight women's Spanish league title with a 4-1 victory over Espanyol.

The win gave Barcelona an insurmountable 16-point lead over second-place Real Madrid.

It is the 11th league title for the Catalan club.

Barcelona has won 25 of its 26 matches in this year's competition. Its only setback was a 1-0 defeat at Real Sociedad in November.

The team, coached by Pere Romeu and led by players such as Alexia Putellas, Aitana Bonmati and Caroline Graham Hansen, has scored 116 goals and conceded seven, with a goal difference of 109. The goal difference for Madrid is 38.

Edoardo Motta saves four penalties in shootout



Lazio's 21-year-old goalkeeper Edoardo Motta saved four consecutive spot kicks as the Roman club beat Atalanta in a penalty shootout to reach the Italian Cup final.

The score was 1-1 after extra time. The first leg ended 2-2.

Motta – who joined Lazio in January – stopped shots from Gianluca Scamacca, Davide Zappacosta, Mario Pasalic and Charles De Ketelaere as Lazio won the shootout 2-1 with Gustav Isaksen and Kenneth Taylor converting for the visitors. Lazio will face Serie A leader Inter Milan in the May 13 final. Inter came back from two goals down for a 3-2 victory over Como on Tuesday after a 0-0 first leg.

Alessio Romagnoli and Pasalic traded goals in the final minutes of regulation. Motta then pushed a header from Scamacca off the post in stoppage time.

Buenos Aires bans stadium confetti after fire sparks panic



Throwing confetti from the stands, one of the most deeply-rooted traditions among soccer fans in Argentina, will no longer be allowed in the capital city of Buenos Aires.

The Buenos Aires Sports Security Committee issued a "preventive" ban on the use of confetti in stadiums in the district on Wednesday, following the fire that broke out during last Sunday's match between River Plate and Boca Juniors at the Monumental Stadium. Firefighters had to intervene to extinguish the flames that damaged several stadium seats and caused spectators to flee.

India’s mistakes exposed at right time, says Harmanpreet Kaur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Johannesburg

Indian women's team captain Harmanpreet Kaur believes her side's below-par performance against South Africa has come at the right time, allowing the management sufficient time to address their shortcomings and "come back strong" for the T20 World Cup in June.

The 'Women in Blue' slumped to their first T20I series defeat since their group-stage exit at the T20 World Cup in October 2024, conceding a five-match rubber 0-3 to South Africa on Wednesday, with two matches still to be played.



Since that early exit at the ICC showpiece, Harmanpreet's side had enjoyed a strong run, winning series against West Indies, England, Sri Lanka and Australia.

"After the last T20 WC, we have won the maximum T20 series, this is the only one we didn't execute the way we were in the last series," Harmanpreet said at the press conference after the team's nine-wicket loss in the third WT20I here on Wednesday. "I think it's good that whatever mistakes we are making are now and not in the World Cup. This is the right time where we can learn and come back strong."

"As a captain I take everything in a positive way. We still have two

THE WOMEN IN BLUE
SLUMPED TO THEIR
FIRST T20I SERIES
DEFEAT SINCE THEIR
GROUP-STAGE EXIT AT
THE T20 WORLD CUP IN
OCTOBER 2024

matches and we can still put up a decent show," she added.

With the T20 World Cup in England and Wales less than two months away, India's struggles, particularly with the ball, will be a concern. While South Africa have claimed 21 Indian wickets in three matches, India have managed just

Indian men eye Thomas Cup encore, women face tough test in Uber Cup Final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Horsens (Denmark)

Banking on a settled core and bolstered by the rise of Ayush Shetty, the Indian men's team will aim to reclaim the title, while the women's side looks to punch above its weight at the BWF Thomas & Uber Cup Finals beginning on Friday.

India will open their campaign against Canada on Friday, followed by matches against Australia on

Monday (April 27) and China on Wednesday (April 29).

Four years ago, India did something unprecedented, annexing the Thomas Cup crown, considered the world team championship of badminton, putting the sport firmly on the radar of the youth in this country. A bunch of bravehearts, led by Kidambi Srikanth and HS Prannoy, defied all odds as they tamed Denmark, Malaysia and Indonesia en route



Man City tops Premier League as Haaland’s winner relegates Burnley

STEVE DOUGLASAP
■ London

Manchester City completed its ominous, late-season rise to the top of the Premier League by beating Burnley 1-0 thanks to Erling Haaland's early goal on Wednesday, ending Arsenal's 200-day stay in first place.

The result condemned American-owned Burnley to relegation after one season back in the top flight.

Haaland ran onto Jeremy Doku's pass to convert a deft finish in the fifth minute for his league-high 24th goal of the campaign, which allowed City to back up its 2-1 victory over Arsenal on Sunday that, for many, turned Pep Guardiola's team into the title favorite.

However, with goal difference potentially coming into play, City might regret not putting more past Burnley at Turf Moor.

Winning by a one-goal margin left City and Arsenal tied on both points (70) and goal difference (+37). City



only leads courtesy of more goals scored (66 to Arsenal's 63). "I was not frustrated, why would I be?" Guardiola said. "We won three points, we are top of the league."

Haaland and Rayan Cherki struck the goal frame and Nico O'Reilly had a weak shot saved with the net at his mercy as City's players threw everything at Burnley – they finished

the game having had 28 shots – in an effort to rack up the goals.

"In these types of games, if you score the second or third that you deserve, everything's more fluid and natural," Guardiola said.

"But," he added, "the main target was winning the game."

City was nine points adrift of Arsenal after

drawing with West Ham on March 14. Three straight wins, combined with back-to-back losses for Arsenal, has seen the title race turn on its head.

Relegation was inevitable for Burnley: For next-to-last Burnley, a third relegation from the Premier League in the last five seasons has been an inevitability for weeks. (AP)

PSG bounces back to open 4-point lead in Ligue 1

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Paris

Khvicha Kvaratskhelia scored twice as Paris Saint-Germain recovered from its Ligue 1 loss to Lyon with a 3-0 victory over relegation-threatened Nantes.

PSG's home win – in a game postponed from mid-March to allow the team to better prepare for its Champions League last-16 clash with Chelsea – keeps it four points above Lens with four rounds of the French league remaining.

Kvaratskhelia opened the scoring from the penalty spot in the 13th minute. It was awarded after a VAR check penalised Nantes defender Frederic Guilbert for handball because



Marquinhos' header brushed against his arm. Louis Leroux thought he'd equalised when he fired in a loose ball after PSG failed to deal with a free kick, but the next VAR decision also went against the visitors. After a lengthy delay, the goal was ruled out for offside.

Kane leads Bayern into German Cup final

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Leverkusen (Germany)

Harry Kane and Luis Diaz fired Bayern Munich into the German Cup final with a 2-0 win at Bayer Leverkusen.

Kane's first-half strike – his 52nd goal of the season across all competitions for his club – and a goal from Diaz in stoppage time were enough for Bayern to advance to a final against Stuttgart or Freiburg in Berlin's Olympiastadion on May 23.

It will be Bayern's first appearance in the final since beating Leverkusen 4-2 to seal a domestic double in 2000. "I've missed Berlin," Bayern goalkeeper Manuel Neuer said after a semifinal in which he had nothing to do until he produced a brilliant flying save to deny Nathan Tella an equaliser with his fingertips.

The win keeps Bayern, which clinched the Bundesliga title on Saturday, on course for a treble of trophies. It faces title holder Paris Saint-Germain in the semifinals of the Champions League with the first leg on Tuesday in Paris.

Kane scored in the 22nd minute after a quickly taken throw on the right. Jamal



Musiala took the ball forward, crossed it and Diaz left it for the better-positioned Kane to scoop it in under the crossbar. The visitors dominated the first half, keeping Leverkusen goalkeeper Mark Flekken busy with 10 shots at goal while the hosts had none.

Diaz put the result beyond doubt on a break, though he was initially flagged offside when Leon Goretzka slid the ball over. Diaz disagreed, wagging his

figure at the flag-bearer, and a VAR check confirmed Bayern could begin the celebrations.

Defending champion Stuttgart hosts Freiburg on Thursday. The semifinals were pushed back a day because Bayern, Stuttgart and Freiburg all played in the Bundesliga on Sunday, the latter because of its participation in the Europa League, where it faces Braga in the semifinals.

Knight Riders home base to host Olympic cricket: ICC CEO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Los Angeles

ICC CEO Sanjog Gupta on Thursday termed the "ground breaking" of the cricket venue for the 2028 Olympics as the fulfilment of a long awaited "promise", noting that the facility, which also serves as the home ground of the Los Angeles Knight Riders, will bring the sport to the global showpiece.

"This is a moment in history because what we are breaking ground on today is not simply a cricket field. We are breaking ground on a promise. A promise that took 128 years to keep," Gupta said.

Gupta was speaking at the ground breaking ceremony of the venue for the Los Angeles

2028 Olympics. Gupta said cricket's return to the Olympics after more than a century marked recognition of the sport's global appeal, following the International Olympic Committee (IOC) approving its inclusion in the Los Angeles Games.

"That's how long the world's second most popular sport, a game played and passionately followed by more than 2.5 billion people, has been missing from the Olympic stage. "When the International Olympic Committee formally approved cricket's inclusion in the Los Angeles 2028 Games, it wasn't just a scheduling announcement. It was a recognition that the



Olympics should reflect the sports that billions of people love," he said.

"The International Cricket Council humbly accepted that recognition with our full commitment." Referring to the venue at Pomona, Gupta said its community driven legacy made it an ideal choice for cricket's Olympic return.

"I can't imagine a better venue than Pomona for the coming together of this promise. The best things in sport happen when ambition meets community, and Pomona is both. "This site has served the people of Los Angeles County as the home of the LA County Fair, as a gathering place for trade, culture,

and celebration," he said. "There is something fitting, almost poetic, about the fact that a venue built on the idea of community coming together will now host a sport that, at its very core, is all about community." Gupta acknowledged the role of the Knight Riders group in developing the venue, highlighting its intent to grow cricket in the United States.

"I want to acknowledge the role the Los Angeles Knight Riders are playing in making this promise possible. The Knight Riders Group, owners of cricket franchises across India, Caribbean, the UAE, and the United States, has made a bold declaration by establishing their official home ground here, with a clear view to positioning this region as a future hub for cricket in America," he said.

Wolvaardt sets up crushing series win for South Africa

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Johannesburg

India scored their highest-ever total against South Africa but still suffered a nine-wicket thrashing at the hands of the home team with skipper Laura Wolvaardt leading the way with a splendid ton in the third women's T20 International.

South Africa thus took an unassailable 3-0 lead to clinch the five-match series here on Wednesday. The remaining two WT20Is in Johannesburg and Benoni are now rendered inconsequential.

Put in to bat, India made 192 for 4 – their highest ever against South Africa – with captain Harmanpreet Kaur and opener Shafali Verma scoring 66 and 64 respectively.

But, South Africa captain Wolvaardt slammed 115 off just 53 balls while her opening partner Sune Luus struck 64 not out off 42 deliveries against a hapless Indian bowling attack to easily chase down the target of 193 with



21 balls to spare. South Africa reached 193 for 1 in 16.3 overs.

This was the third highest successful run chase in women's T20I history after West Indies and England overhauled 212 and 198 against Australia and India respectively in 2023 and 2018.

Wolvaardt, who has been in top form in the series having made 51 and 54 in the first two matches, struck as many as 14 boundaries and five sixes while toying with the Indian bowlers. Luus, who had made 13 and 57 in the first two matches, hit six boundaries and two sixes.

Chennai Super Kings beat Mumbai Indians by 103 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

India's recent T20 World Cup-winning hero Sanju Samson was back at his best with an unbeaten 101 before spinners tightened the noose as Chennai Super Kings crushed Mumbai Indians by 103 runs in an IPL clash between two five-time champions, here on Thursday.

Samson smashed his fifth IPL century, second for CSK in four innings, to power Chennai Super Kings to 207/6 after Mumbai Indians opted to bowl. In reply, MI collapsed to 104 all out in 19

overs to succumb to their biggest defeat in the IPL.

Samson anchored a faltering Chennai Super Kings with his second century of the season, steering the visitors to a competitive 207 for six against Mumbai Indians in their Indian Premier League clash at the Wankhede Stadium on Thursday.

With wickets falling around him due to poor shot selection and lack of application, the India wicketkeeper-batter held firm, pacing his innings to perfection and playing each delivery on merit to script another memorable knock.

Samson carried his bat in a

fluent 101 not out, an innings studded with 10 fours and six maximums off just 54 balls, but Chennai Super Kings, who looked set for a much bigger total at one stage, lost their way in the middle overs as none of the other batters converted their starts.

Jasprit Bumrah (1/31) began with a tight opening over, though Samson still managed to pierce the field with a crisp drive through cover-point before flicking Hardik Pandya (0/38) off his pads for a six.

CSK had earlier made a bright start, with skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad (22) and Samson



taking 19 runs each off Pandya's first two overs in the powerplay, and despite a couple of early wickets, the visitors were well placed at 73 for two.

Gaikwad looked to be easing back into form, beginning with a heave on the on-side off Pandya before pulling the pacer for a six to take 19 runs from the second over.

However, his promising start was cut short when he went inside-out against AM Ghazanfar (2/25) in the third over, only to be smartly caught by Tilak Varma running in from long-off.

There was also no happy homecoming for Mumbai

players in the CSK camp, with Sarfaraz Khan (14) and Shivam Dube (5) failing to make an impact.

Despite being struck for a couple of boundaries on the on-side by Sarfaraz, Mitchell Santner responded by floating one up on the stumps, just a touch shorter in length, and as if premeditated, Sarfaraz went for his trademark sweep but was undone by the dip as the ball crashed into his stumps.

Coming in at No. 4, India all-rounder Dube had the license to take on the spinners, but he was undone by the drift generated by

Ghazanfar in the ninth over, the ball sneaking past his inside edge and crashing into the stumps.

Dewald Brevis struck a few powerful blows in his 11-ball 21 before falling to a well-directed short ball from Ashwani Kumar (2/37), forced to reach for it well outside off-stump.

Amid the collapses around him, Samson blended caution with aggression to keep the scoreboard ticking, and in the final over, he capped his effort in style by smashing Krish Bhagat for a towering six over cover before pulling the last ball to bring up his sixth IPL hundred.

RR pacer Nandre Burger fined for breaching IPL code of conduct



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Rajasthan Royals pacer Nandre Burger has been fined 10 per cent of his match fees for breaching the IPL code of conduct during his team's match against Lucknow Super Giants here.

The 30-year-old was also handed a demerit point, an IPL statement said on Thursday.

"Nandre Burger, Bowler,

Rajasthan Royals (RR) has been fined 10 percent of his match fees and has also accumulated One Demerit Point for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct during his team's match against Lucknow Super Giants (LSG)," the statement added.

Burger was found to have breached the Article 2.5 of the IPL's code of conduct "pertaining to using language, actions or gestures which disparage or which could

provoke an aggressive reaction from another player in the Match."

The left-arm pacer admitted to the offence.

For Level 1 breaches of the Code of Conduct, the Match Referee's decision is final and binding.

The Royals rode on an all-round performance by the bowling unit to inflict a 40-run defeat on hosts LSG on Wednesday.

Langer compares Ekana pitch to WACA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Lucknow Super Giants head coach Justin Langer compared the Ekana pitch to the famed Perth track of yesteryears, admitting that the home team has been unable to adapt to the pace and bounce on offer on it.

The LSG have struggled on their home surface, losing all three matches here. They have gone down by six and seven wickets to Delhi Capitals and Gujarat Titans respectively, before suffering a 40-run defeat to Rajasthan Royals on Wednesday.

The LSG lost six of their eight matches here last season, including five in a row. Overall, they have managed just nine wins from 25 games at the venue.

"The pitch here is very different than in most of India. It's a brilliant cricket pitch. You see pace and bounce, and we just haven't quite adjusted to it," Langer said at the post-match press conference.

"I thought we'd started off, we'd been bowling quite well in it. We bowled well in the first game, but we're just not adjusting to the extra pace and bounce. We saw that we've been out to the short ball a number of times, our batters.

"We see a lot of the wickets in India where the ball doesn't bounce very high. This is like playing at the WACA. There's real pace and bounce. You're seeing some really interesting cricket being played here," he added.

Despite boasting a formidable batting line-up featuring skipper Rishabh Pant, Australia's Mitchell



Marsh, South Africa T20 captain Aiden Markram and the flamboyant Nicholas Pooran, LSG have struggled to put up competitive totals at home, managing 141, 164 for 8 and 119 in three games.

"Our batting's just not quite clicking, and who would have thought at the start of the season our batting wouldn't click with the calibre of players we've got? We could never have read that, so we're working hard on it."

The former Australia coach, however, had words of praise for the bowling

unit, predicting a bright future for young pacers Prince Yadav and Mohsin Khan.

"Last year our numbers were incredible and we were ruing the fact that a lot of our bowlers were injured or coming back from injury or not quite fit.

"This year our bowlers have been a real credit. I think Mohsin Khan, again outstanding. Prince Yadav, I think they're both two players who will play for India. No question in my mind they'll both play for

India." On whether the franchise had any say in pitch preparation, Langer dismissed the notion.

"No, no, no. Their groundsmen here: I've said for the last couple of years this is one of the best pitches in India."

"It's a big ground. It's a brilliant bat... it's a great cricket wicket actually and we just need to adapt to it better."

Meanwhile, all-rounder Ravindra Jadeja, who struck an unbeaten 43 and picked up a wicket to guide Rajasthan to victory, said the surface was far from an ideal T20 wicket.

"The wicket wasn't very easy. There was grass, it was a red-soil wicket, so there was bounce as well. Their four fast bowlers were making it swing and seam alongside good pace.

"I wouldn't say it was ideally a T20 wicket, you couldn't just go and swing at it and get runs. Fast bowlers from both teams would have enjoyed that they could bounce and seam it," Jadeja said.

However, the seasoned all-rounder appreciated the consistency of the pitch across both the innings.

"What I liked was that the wicket was equal for both. It's not like how it is sometimes, when batters first get a slow, seaming wicket and then nothing happens in the second innings. Both teams lost two-three wickets in the Powerplay itself.

"It was a challenging T20 match, not the typical one with fireworks from both sides. It challenges you mentally, and skill-wise you have to be sharp," he said.

Shardul Thakur, Siddhesh Lad named Cricketers of the Year during MCA awards

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Shardul Thakur and Siddhesh Lad were named Cricketers of the Year for seasons 2024-25 and 2025-26 respectively during the MCA Awards ceremony on Wednesday. Thakur and Lad were awarded with Justice Tendolkar Trophy for the best senior cricketer for the 2024-25 and 2025-26 seasons respectively.

During the ceremony, Mumbai-based players and coaches who have contributed in India's triumphs in global competitions were also felicitated. Young batter Ayush Mhatre was honoured for leading the Indian U-19 team to a record-extending sixth World Cup title earlier this

year in South Africa, along with wicketkeeper-batter Abhigyan Kundu.

India T20I captain Suryakumar Yadav and all-rounder Shivam Dube were honoured for their contributions in the team's record extending third T20 World Cup title last month.

Jemimah Rodrigues, India women's head coach Amol Muzumdar, and bowling coach Aavishkar Salvi were honoured for their contributions to the country's maiden ODI World Cup win last year.

Sanika Chalke from the Under-19 women's World Cup-winning squad was also honoured.

"Mumbai's dominance across domestic cricket in the 2024-25 season was further



reinforced as MCA felicitated its champion teams that clinched major titles, including the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, Senior Women's T20 Trophy, Under-14 West Zone Championship, Under-23 Women's One-Day Trophy,



Vijay Merchant Trophy (Under-16), and the Women's Under-15 One-Day Trophy, underlining the association's sustained excellence across age groups and formats," the MCA said in a release.

The event was attended

by the legendary Sunil Gavaskar, Dilip Vengsarkar, Rajeev Kulkarni, Diana Edulji, Maharashtra cabinet ministers Ashish Shelar and Aditi Tatkare, along with MCA president Ajinkya Naik and the governing body's apex

council members. Vengsarkar urged the young players to contribute to Mumbai's success.

"Mumbai has a strong cricketing ecosystem — from the Harris Shield and Giles Shield to U-19 and inter-collegiate tournaments — which has long served as a supply line for talent," Vengsarkar said.

"It continues to produce players who are the future of Mumbai and Indian cricket. I hope you all play for India. I am not saying that you shouldn't play the IPL as it is also important, but you must contribute to Mumbai's success," he added.

The ceremony also honoured a few other cricketers and administrators with the Lifetime Achievement Awards.

Om Satija attempts to run the length of India



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Undertaking an extraordinary 5,000 km 'One India Run' from Kanyakumari to Kashmir, Indo-Australian athlete Om Satija is attempting to become the youngest to run the length of India.

Now on day 87 of the journey, the 23-year-old from Melbourne has already completed approximately 4,000 kilometres and is approaching Delhi, averaging close to 50 km per day.

Satija aims to become the first person to run the east coast of India and youngest person to run the length of the country, marking an historic milestone in Indian endurance sport, a media release stated.

The run aims to raise ₹60 lakh in funds for Udayan Kolkata, a charity that works with children from marginalised and leprosy-affected communities.

"The money will help educate 1,000 children over the next five years; this impact equates to just ₹1,200 per kilometre of the run," the release said.

"The project has already raised close to ₹17 lakh, with momentum continuing to build through community events and grassroots support," it added.

Thushara withdraws case against SLC over IPL NOC



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Fast bowler Nuvan Thushara, who had dragged Sri Lanka Cricket (SLC) to court for not issuing him a No Objection Certificate (NOC) for competing in the IPL, on Thursday withdrew the case against the governing body.

The player with 30 T20 international appearances since 2022, pleaded that the SLC had refused to issue him a NOC, saying that he

had failed fitness tests. His attorney told the district court that since most of the games in the IPL have already been completed, his client wished to withdraw the case which the court upheld.

He apologised to the SLC and indicated his willingness to withdraw the case.

Thushara was to appear for defending champions Royal Challengers Bangalore (RSB) this season having previously played in 2024 and 2025.

I have no answers: Pant on batting collapse

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

A distraught Lucknow Super Giants captain Rishabh Pant did not have any answer for his team's defence after a morale-crushing 40-run defeat against Lucknow Super Giants in an IPL match, other than accepting the responsibility that his side didn't read the surface properly.

"I don't have answers. Batting has let us down. We are disappointed as a team, as a group," Pant said after his team were skittled out for 119 chasing a small 160-run target. "You have to look for answers inside, not outside. We could have taken some time while batting. No excuses out there. Including myself, we could have taken it



deeper. As a batting group, we have to put our hands up," Pant offered a feeble explanation.

Mohammed Shami's bowling effort stood out and Pant found that to be a silver lining.

"We have to look at positives.

We have to keep our head high and look for answers inside. We have the firepower to turn the season around."

Rajasthan Royals skipper Rryan Parag knew that there was help off the surface.

"We knew it would swing, the lines and lengths they (Nandre Burger and Jofra Archer) bowled, impressive. The message on the groups have been very positive," Rryan said after the match.